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THE ABBEY WOOD AND THAMESMEAD

PEOPLE

Independently produced in Thamesmead by, and for, the community ✤ ISSN 1355-9087 ✤ Volume 7, Edition 11, June 2001

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We're not daft!

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

MANY have doubted the sanity of the publishers of this paper because of its stance on the election of EMB members to the board of Gallions Housing Association. While we'll always support the right to hold varying views, we don't have to agree with them!

NEW

There are many people now residing in the town who know nothing of the fights that dot our history as residents fought for democracy.

Some of these people (and come on, wake up, they'll be in the majority one day) are tenants of Gallions now, more will be so in the future. They all deserve the best *current* chance to get accountable control of the management of their homes and town.

That is what, we believe, has been achieved thus far by the EMBs. The best chance. So far. You go for a bit of power, get it, then go for more. That's the history of fighters and for sure, this community's always been well populated with fighters!

If a large enough vote can be recorded in these elections those who fought for them will be vindicated.

If the "recipe for doing nothing" merchants have their way there will be no vindication, only a giving in to unaccountable diktat. The choice is, we feel, only too bitterly clear.

We think that's a good enough reason to put our money where our mouths are, as we have doneby running the dual promotion of the election with Gallions.

GET INVOLVED

Here's where it's at: get involved or leave it to those who want power without accountability. Get involved or watch your town change around you – without a say. Get involved, or watch others' involvement discount you.

RIGHT?

No-one says that the EMB members who've worked so hard for this election have got it right every time – they are just getting it right *some* of the time. They all, we all, need help to raise the percentage of right results. The help of members of this community.

HISTORY

Nationally and locally, there is a massive disillusionment withe the political process. Why? **Because those in power won't give the power to others to call them to account.** It is up to this quite unique community, this time, to exercise the old mainstay of democracy: take an intelligent informed part in a voting process and make those in power accountable.

EASY?

Did we say it would be easy? No. Nor would we. But it's worthwhile going for it. It's worthwhile identifying yourselves as fighters for democracy and respecters of your friends and neighbours. Isn't it?

No burger for Alpha

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

THE picture right is of Alpha – a well-trained Service Dog (and of course good friend) who accompanies local lady Sorinda Bridge-water. Alpha's job is to care for and watch over Sorinda, a lupus sufferer with other medical problems who sometimes has recourse to wheelchair use.

COMMENDED

Sorinda has many letters of commendation about Alpha and his behaviour, from various hospitals and medical centres but especially from a variety of well-known eating places. Rightly, Sorinda is proud of them.

TOWN CENTRE

On a visit to Thamesmead town centre (in the wheelchair), Sorinda thought she'd stop awhile for refreshment in the burger bar, by the clock tower.

Oh no! Unceremoniously she was shown the door. No dogs. Any dogs. Service Dogs or no.

Angry Sorinda rang the *People* eventually and a kind friend brought her and Alpha to visit, to tell us of her experience (hence the photograph). Alpha is a bright, intelligent, impeccably behaved dog.

But, it seems, the proprietors of the burger bar don't share that view – of Alpha or the wheelchair.

The authorities (Greenwich) are being notified of this denial of the rights of the disabled and they will no doubt ensure that the burger bar changes its attitude towards the disabled and their accompanying service dogs.

But generally, proprietors had better check that they do not treat the disabled so, because the disabled will not stay silent. Eh Sorinda?



Pretty boy Alpha on parade

Gang of scum

JAMES LONG

This is a follow-up to a recently published letter

LAST month I wrote to you about the coots' nest at the bottom of Tavy Bridge. I said how my son and I kept watch on it to stop certain types of kids throwing things onto the nest.

Well, on Friday night at about eleven o'clock I was on my balcony looking at the nest through binoculars, when a bunch of kids leaned over the fence near the nest. One of them threw something very heavy at the nest. I could hear one of the birds screeching in pain.

I rang the Police straight away, then my son and I went over to the nest. When we got there, one of the birds was dead, the other bird with three babies was swimming around very distressed. This gang of scum should be very proud of what they did. Lots of us in Southmere get a lot of enjoyment from watching these two coots and their babies – now this has been spoilt by a lot of vicious scum-bags.

I really believe that if these people are caught their parents should be evicted, as they are not bringing their children up properly. I determined to catch these animals who did this.

One clue I have is one of them was wearing a baseball cap, a red jumper and was using a pair of crutches. They went off in the direction of Hartslock Drive.

If you know who they are, tell the Police, as it is a criminal offence to harm wild birds.

BRIGHTER NOTE

On a brighter note, can I please thank the housing officer from Gallions Housing who rang me after my last letter appeared complaining of cables hanging from Binsey Walk.

She rang to tell me that the cables had all been fixed. As I said in my last letter, I always get excellent service from Gallions Housing – thank you very much for having the time to ring me.

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Thanks to the donations of goods from local companies the volunteers were kept busy all day creating the scenes all around the building.

The teachers, governors and pupils and parents from the school all worked alongside the local community volunteers, arranged by Volunteers Greenwich and supported by Queen Mary Hospital Millennium Volunteers, and our own local charity, Respond.

The day was coordinated by Michelle White and Luise Legemah from the Volunteers Greenwich Abbey Wood and Thamesmead project, and was by far the most challenging project taken on by them – designed to form part of the National Volunteering Week.

The generosity of local businesses make these projects possible and special thanks go to Ironmonger Erith, Dulux Decorator Centre, Thamesmead Landscapes Limited, Southlake Primary School, D&M Butchers, Makros in Charlton, Mustang Marketing Services, Volunteers Greenwich and Respond.

The Volunteers are working on new projects in the area, so to be involved, telephone Michelle or Luise on 020 8316 6644.









The chair of governors presents the certificates

Top picture, just some of the volunteers. Others show glimpses of the intense and varied hard work they did, over more than the one day, giving Southlake children a nice surprise the next Monday



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DRY CLEANERS AND TAILORS

IN THE EDITOR'S OPINION



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And they send their precious little minions scuttling round Millbank crying "Woe is us, no-one respects politicians any more!" I've heard of being out of touch, but this government's attitudes seem to indicate a gulf of unique proportions.

If anybody in what's left of my old party (which I left when the arrogant b******s privatised the doctors who check disability claimants) has the temerity to defend the dishonour of this sad government, will they try it by defending the "market" they seem to adore? I wouldn't like anyone to get the wrong impression by the way, this is not a subtle defence of the true blues for, truthfully, is there anything that *could* defend that aimless rabble?

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Well, that was a good old rant, wasn't it? I meant it though, I was cumulatively angry!

What about something you've all forgotten by now? A few weeks back the anti-union tv stations were raving on about the hold-ups to the Royal Mail (do you remember when that meant something?) they were keen to warn of the dangers to "democracy" because of the threat to the postal votes in the general election.

As is known in the industry and was revealed to me by a reliable source, the "Thatcher Rambo" style of management is the cause of the breakdowns and ill-feeling.

And the reason for the disgusting behaviour of these managers? They're getting ready for the privatisation that will give them bigger pay packets they've been told. Which means they've got to kick the staff into submission first.

How have they tried that? The backlog of mail caused by this sad management's actions needed clearing. But it wasn't.

No extra working, no overtime to clear it – "you held it up, you clear it!" was the negotiating stance – they put *some* special measures on though. *They management held up the first-class post to get the election mail out.* Service? To the public?

Get out of it! All you people who suffered because your mail was late should be clear who to blame and it's *not* the Post Office workers! How sad that so many dutiful workers in the media daren't rock the boat and tell the truth about the charade of privatisation.

Well other than all this, it's been nice to feel the sun on my back and good to see the roses out. Rosemarie tells me that Southmere Park is sodden with the thundery rain we've had and I think that's fine, as long as we get the sun in between. Mind you, I've not been caught out in it!

I hope to see you all at the Festival in Birchmere Park – perhaps have a pint together – let's all enjoy the community enjoying itself.

WELCOME!

If you are a new resident of Abbey Wood and Thamesmead the *Thamesmead People* welcomes you to this busy community. We strive to picture all that is happening here: the good, the bad, the ugly and most of all, the wealth of our community. We provide you with the only honest and uncensored letters pages available in the area and with the most accurate recording of events.

You may treat this as *your* newspaper. We hope you will be happy here.



"Ere, gel, dja 'ear dat Blair give isself a rise?"

"Yeah – blurry supprise innit … "

"Dja reckon we'll gerra rise too?"

"Nah, we've voted nah, intwe?"

'Step on the bus ...



"I'm at Trust Thamesmead, seconded from Bexley College. The Trust gained European Social Fund money for the StepUp scheme. Under that I've arranged a FREE bus service for eligible people in the Thamesmead area on courses at Bexley College. I can help you ... ring me – about the bus, and about College training!"
Francoise Sillett



'Step into training ... StepUp to employment!'

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"I'm in the StepUp team at the Trust and, under StepUp, unemployed residents of the Thamesmead area can be assisted with • free training • help to find work, with a list of current vacancies • careers advice and help with CVs • support with tools and/or travel, including the FREE bus to Bexley College. I can tell you about our training and employment help. Call me, or call in at the Trust offices."
Sharron Feetham

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Francoise rings the bell

PRESS RELEASE

AS related last month, through hard work and European money, Francoise Sillett has provided a free bus to help qualifying residents of the area make the awkward journey to Bexley College's three campuses.

LET DOWN

Seconded to Trust Thamesmead from Bexley College, Francoise is already well-known to *People* readers for her frequent appearances with Volunteers Greenwich on their local projects and her support to local community groups.

While bringing her teaching and organisational skills to her work here, she learned the geography of our large town – soon discovering how important (and difficult) was the road link from the community to Bexley College.

HARD

Of course unemployed people find it hard to provide bus fares and course fees to enable the further study dictated by today's employment needs. The StepUp programme meets this problem head-on – and more.

With the StepUp scheme that gained the European money and with team members Janice, Sharron and Dawn, there's a lot of assistance being organised for the unemployed people of Abbey Wood and Thamesmead.

A chat with Sharron reveals that the comprehensive assistance for the unemployed continues, with an understanding ability to assist with start-up problems associated with new jobs (fares, tools, clothes, help with childcare, *etc*).

Perhaps the most important aspect is the wide spread of the attack on unemployment problems. Liaison with jobs databases, employers and assisting agencies is all part of the deal. Some people find the greatest assistance is from Bexley College's deeply experienced careers/jobs advice officers – obviously personally known to Francoise!

Courses for all stages of development and in just about all the theatres of employment (yes, the theatre too!) are available there, and Francoise's bus can get you there now – from St Joseph's to Tower Road!

GEOGRAPHY

The planning of the route, within various constraints, has given a route intended to have the centres aimed at by the European money, (as quoted last month, the postcoded areas of SE2, SE28 and DA18) as catchment areas.

While the bus should be travelling the roads intended it should also, of course, be recognisable. That's why we've taken care to publish the photograph above, so that you'll be able to recognise which bus you've missed when you get up late!

THANKS

Mean while, Francoise asked that her thanks, with Trust Thamesmead's, be passed on to Mr Peter Hiller (pictured right), of Morgan Elliott in Belvedere for his assistance in acquiring the bus.

PROGRESS

With reports coming in from Francoise as we print of hundreds of interested applicants registering with StepUp, it would seem that the aims of the European Social Fund are being well met.

If this project means that a notable portion of this community has its future changed – and brightened – then we should all be pleased.

Power to your elbows, Francoise and Sharron – you're working well!



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No extra working, no overtime to clear it – "you held it up, you clear it!" was the negotiating stance – they put *some* special measures on though. *They management held up the first-class post to get the election mail out.* Service? To the public?

Get out of it! All you people who suffered because your mail was late should be clear who to blame and it's *not* the Post Office workers! How sad that so many dutiful workers in the media daren't rock the boat and tell the truth about the charade of privatisation.

Well other than all this, it's been nice to feel the sun on my back and good to see the roses out. Rosemarie tells me that Southmere Park is sodden with the thundery rain we've had and I think that's fine, as long as we get the sun in between. Mind you, I've not been caught out in it!

I hope to see you all at the Festival in Birchmere Park – perhaps have a pint together – let's all enjoy the community enjoying itself.

WELCOME!

If you are a new resident of Abbey Wood and Thamesmead the *Thamesmead People* welcomes you to this busy community. We strive to picture all that is happening here: the good, the bad, the ugly and most of all, the wealth of our community. We provide you with the only honest and uncensored letters pages available in the area and with the most accurate recording of events.

You may treat this as *your* newspaper. We hope you will be happy here.



"'Ere, gel, dja 'ear dat Blair give isself a rise?"

"Yeah – blurry supprise innit . . . "

"Dja reckon we'll gerra rise too?"

"Nah, we've voted nah, innwe?"

The whole town coming together for a Summer's day


GILES

Giles Randall rang the *People*: "I'm creating and running the Summer Festival this year – would you like to assist?" *Would* we! So we joined with Giles and his colleague Nick Riley in creating this spread, to announce the biggest day in this area's Summer, the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Summer Festival


NICK

"We're trying to bring the whole town together for a day," said Giles.

Giles and Nick head "Community-Plus", created by Trust Thamesmead, with their own budget and with unfettered responsibility for this festival.

Reporting only to the Trust's board, these two hard-working lads have devised and collated, consulted and cajoled and are now in the breathless run-up to the day itself.

CommunityPlus
TRUST THAMESMEAD COMMUNITY INVOLVEMENT



First of their tasks after they started planning was to give our local schools as long a preparation time as possible.

SCHOOLS

Each school was given freedom to choose its theme for a float for involvement in the Festival Parade and the Festival in Birchmere Park. Their work commenced. Months ago.

Now, a little secretively, it all nears completion.

CATERING

Then the catering facilities. By far the most important part, the supply of the cuppas! This could not be trusted to just anyone. The ladies at Waterways Nursery (pictured below) were contacted and they jumped at the idea. A chance to earn to subsidise the Nursery! Of course! We know how good their cakes supply is from their garden fetes.

Giles said "And I wanted, as far as possible, to keep proceeds in the town for our community's benefit."

AGE GROUPS

Giles told of the consideration given to providing for the varied age groups of the community.

"There's been a distinct move to give people of all ages a good bite of the cherry this time. With the Bungee jumps and the Parabounce added to Trevor Cross's mad 'It's a Knock-out' to the plentiful supply of all kinds of music and shoot 'em up games, there's great variety."

OLDER

The needs of older people, with the provision of seating in Birchmere Park and varieties of stalls and entertainment, is looked after.

PROCESSION

The day will start with the Parade – all the way from the assembly point at the roundabout at the foot of Knee Hill, along Harrow Manor Way, up over the elevated round-about to cross the spine road then down and left into Bentham Road, thence to Birchmere Park.

The route has been planned with the assistance of the Metropolitan Police.

This parade will certainly be musical. In it, there will be **Jamabalya** a New Orleans-style jazz band; **Viramundo**, a Brazilian Samba Band and **Sahara Harem** – North African drums and dancers!

Remember, 12 of our local schools will be represented in the Parade by their individual floats and you will know how hard our little 'uns will have worked on them.

FREE

Nearly everything is free on the day.

There are some exceptions, of course, like the catering, the Fun Fair and some trade stalls placed there for your greater choice. But nearly all is free!

BIRCHMERE

At lunchtime, Birchmere Park will fill with the arriving Parade and the many local groups and organisations making presentations on the day.

There will be YAP from Tavy Bridge and the YMCA from South-mere Lake, and that's just two from about 50 groups!

There will be things like the Parabounce, taking the adventurous on brief sightseeing trips over Thamesmead; a Bungee Jump for the plain mad; an Arcade Zone for electronic adventuring; a huge children's village; inflatables and sandpits; water games *and* a Fun Fair!


Remember these faces (from now, and costumes from last year!)?


A crane of the type that will launch the bu jumps – without letting go!


Waterways ladies – caterers to the town, for a day!

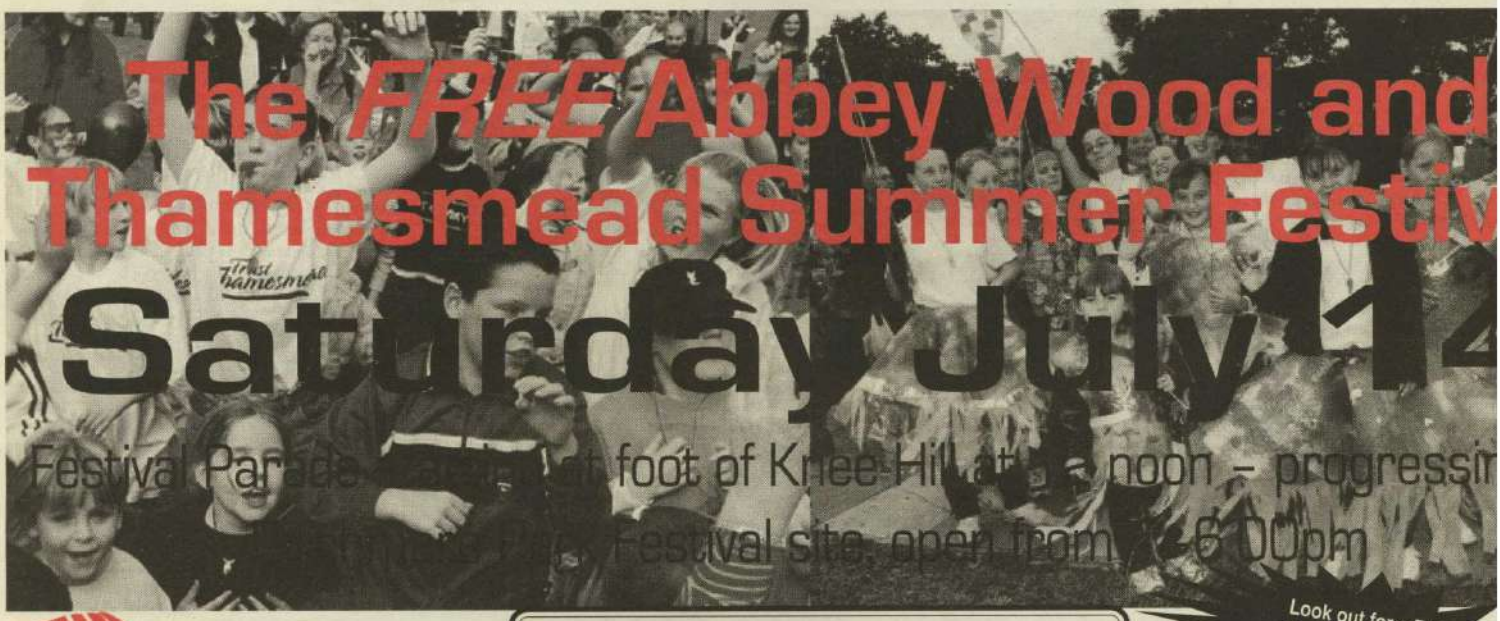


Trust Thamesmead telephone number for enquiries 020 8320 447

CommunityPlus

TRUST THAMESMEAD COMMUNITY INVOLVEMENT

Presents ...



The *FREE* Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Summer Festiv

Saturday July 14

Festival Parade ... foot of Knee Hill at ... noon – progressin ...

... Festival site, open from ... 6.00pm

NEW! Parabounce!

A "lucky dip" draw for rides!

SOAR 100' HIGH IN ONE GIANT LEAP!



The Refreshment Marquee and Beer Garden will be enclosed, with a small stage outside, with outdoor tables and chairs. There will be other catering units around the site as well

PARABOUNCE • BUNGEE JUMP
IT'S A KNOCKOUT!

Human Table Football • Gladiator Joust • Sumo Wrestling
Rodeo Bull • 4 x Quad Bikes • 46ft Commando Assault
Ball Pond • River Rapid Slide • Bungee Run

CHILDREN'S VILLAGE

Inflatable Disco Bounce • Under 5 Area Inflatables
Enchanted Forest • Clown Bouncer • Ball Pond •
Soft Play Roundabout • Ball Crawl Maze • Cube Maze
6 Rodeo Ball • Small Inflatable Toys

6–8 YEARS

Inflatable Slide • Inflatable King Kong • Ball Pond • Inflatable Castle

WALKABOUT CLOWN

Balloon Artist • Creative Activity • Splats Circus Workshop
Puppet Show • Hair Beader • Face Painting

Marquees for nappy changing units and lost children, etc

TRUST ZONE

Dunk Tank 300 • 10-Gun Laser Shoot • Coconut Shy
Froggit Water Game • Laser Quasar • Inflatable Nessie
Free Popcorn

GIANT JENGA

Aunt Sally Water Game • Stocks Water Game

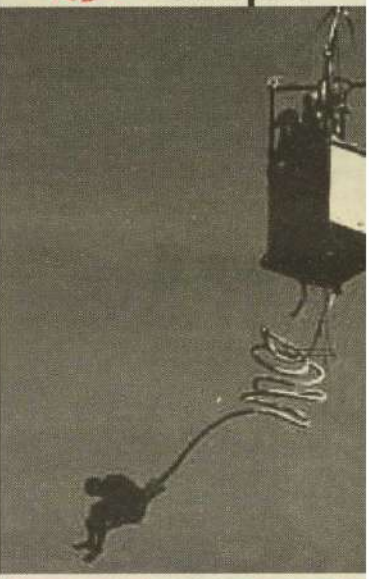
OTHER AREAS

16-seat Simulator Ride • Big Blue Rock Climbing Tower

The Sega World and Laser Show
ALL TRADEMARKS ACKNOWLEDGED
2 x Sega Rally Twin Drivers • 2 x Sega Ski Simulators
1 x Manx TT Motor Bike Simulator • 1 x Virtual Cop, Twin Shooter
1 x Virtual Striker Football Simulator • 1 x Rail Chase 2, twin
rollercoaster Ride • 2 x Pinball Machines
2 x table Football Games

Look out for a Free Programme in your letterbox soon!

NEW! 160ft Bur... Jumps! A "lu... draw

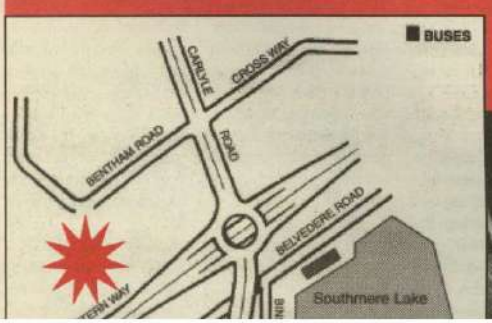


All started off by the exciting, colourful, and musical, spectacular,

FESTIVAL PARADE

starting 12 noon from the roundabout at the foot of Knee Hill to Birchmer...

Look out for your free programmes in Gallions Housing Association and Trust Thamesmead meeting halls, etc







MEDICAL MATTERS

by Dr P Anand, GP at Lakeside Health Centre

PREVENTION IS BETTER THAN A CURE!

When I was a boy my father used to quote many sayings to me! His favourite one was "Procrastination is the thief of time!" He always threw this at me when he thought I was slacking academically or being a bit lazy. He used these statements to try to encourage me to pull my socks up and maintain high standards, or even do better. Nowadays, this is called "Clinical Governance!" This is an idea about how to run our organisations better and deliver what is now called best care or "Evidence Based" medicine.

The Royal College of General Practitioners is another voluntary organisation that GPs can try and join by taking various types of examinations.

Whether this is good or bad I don't want to debate today, but they also advocate seizing the opportunity to further a patient's health and health understanding. It is called taking up cues and giving options.

A doctor should recognise a lead in what a patient says to him or her and explore the lead adequately. In all this a GP today is supposed to further health education and to practise *prevention* and so make the need for fewer *cures*!

This process of "prevention is better than cure" starts even before we are born now. Mothers are advised on best health, diet and exercise. Folic acid prevents *spina bifida*. Genetic tests can warn parents of problems in themselves and in their children to be.

The pregnancy itself is subject to blood tests for German measles or *rubella*, *syphilis*, *cytomegalovirus*, HIV and others, and regular ultra sound scans.

Babies have to go through immunisation programmes which stretch from the BCG at birth, protection against meningitis, polio, tetanus, whooping cough or pertussis and diphtheria from two months of age to repeated vaccinations up to the age of 15 years.

Travel vaccinations and TB and malaria prevention are essential. Prevention is much better.

In our own lives we are all advised on controlled alcohol consumption. We are told a few units of red wine a day are good for us. Tobacco in any form is a suicide recipe! Our diets are so well analysed now – no-one can claim ignorance about basic ideas on the goodness of fruit and vegetables, a controlled meat diet, low fat and grilled better than fried.

Exercise and its uses in controlling stamina and weight, thus preventing heart disease and high blood pressure, is championed everywhere. Yet we see limited areas for children to play, since pets foul all public parks and this is a nightmare for all, including pet owners. They need their areas, too. How do you please everyone? Which parents in their right minds will allow children out on their own to play?

The dangers of *obesity* from heart disease, to strokes, to arthritis. Prevent overweight occurring. We can all play a part in this ourselves!

Despite all that medicine can do, it is still apparent to me that the greatest steps in preventing ill health have to come from social and environmental achievements. People need balanced, understanding upbringing. They need a secure, stable home and psychological environment. They need hot water, warmth and good food. All benefit from a good education with a caring school environment and affordable education. I am very concerned about the way university education is being made unaffordable for some. I come from a family of seven children. All four of the boys are doctors. We would never have achieved this if the old grant system had not helped us. We would not be able to do this today.

So much of this depends on recognising danger signs and preventing problems. Tell the editor of this paper, tell your MP and help identify worries and encourage people in power to act early and prevent problems. Many cures are available and very good, but to not have to face a problem in the first place has to be better.

Thank God we are having some sunshine at last!

RESPOND (THAMESMEAD) LTD

Clothes and Baby Centre

Clothesbank: new and used clothes available at low cost. **Baby clothes:** new and used baby clothes available at low cost. **Baby Accessories:** push chairs, prams and other accessories. **House accessories:** kitchen utensils, crockery, tea towels, etc.

Come visit us at 2–6 Griffin Manorway, West Thamesmead Business Park – we're open from 10 to 2, Monday to Friday

Near to Plumstead Railway Station and two minutes' walk from Plumstead Bridge

New working group



PRESS RELEASE

TO build on their record of assisting local people, Emmanuel Church has formed a new group from within the wider community. some of the 20 or so members are shown in the picture (supplied by John Wylie) having just shared an excellent buffet produced by Bexley College Caterers.

This group was asked to explore the refurbishing of the building and ways to maximise its usefulness to the community.

It is now proposed to make the premises more suitable for running a wide range of activities by changing the first floor flats into offices and a meeting room for training courses, small conferences and to be used by local residents for family events.

Therefore it is necessary to improve and upgrade all the amenities, and in particular to develop the first floor area and access ways.

The management committee held a working lunch on May 17 and invited a range of professional people to contribute ideas, starting by volunteering their services.

Some 19 guests arrived and after an introduction by Vic Lambert, toured the building and formed various working parties.

These working parties reported back on June 14 with some outline plans.

GILERA RUNNER



GILERA is gearing up for the Summer with the launch of the new Runner VX 125cc and VXR 180cc.

The four-stroke, four valve, liquid-cooled VX and VXR perfectly combine excellent fuel economy with outstanding performance.

This performance has made the Gilera Runner the best-selling "sport commuter" scooter in the 50cc, 125cc and 180cc categories, with over 100,000 units sold in the last three years.

The new models are powered by the latest four-stroke Leader engines which deliver 15bhp at 9,700rpm for the VX (the maximum permitted by European standards for holders of car driving licences and the highest output of any 125cc scooter) and 20bhp for the VXR. All of this power is put to good use, guiding the Runner VX to a maximum speed of 67mph, while the Runner VXR can reach 75mph and both are capable of maintaining excellent average speeds over long distances.

The Gilera Runner VX 125cc and VXR 180cc – the ultimate sports commuter scooter

The performance does not come at the loss of fuel economy with both the Runner VX and VXR achieving an average fuel consumption figure of 77mpg, while intervals between oil changes can be doubled due to the Leader engines' efficiency.

Allied to the Runner's impressive performance are good looks. Its aluminium alloy wheels, fitted with low profile tubeless tyres, and new hydraulic front forks with 35mm stanchions accentuate the sporty appearance of the VX and VXR and improve stability, comfort and safety.

Available in a colour range including matt grey, combined with bright fluoro red or yellow, or alternatively sleek aluminium, the VX and VXR are priced on the road at £2,299 and £2,549 respectively.

Also, with standard equipment including an anti-theft immobiliser, the Gilera Runner VX and VXR, although bargains, needn't be a steal!

INSURANCE

From now until September 30, the Gilera Runner VX is even better value with great savings on insurance.

Gilera is offering those aged between 16 and 24 up to £200 off a year's third party fire and theft insurance on selected Gilera models, including the revolutionary DNA 50cc, Runner SP50cc, Runner SP125cc and Runner VX 125cc.

CONTACT

For more information, readers should call Gilera on 0800 20 30 10 and quote reference FP069.

ROSIE'S HERE



Neighbours tend to be like your family – if you can't get on with them and the situation becomes unbearable, you can't just pack and move house.

And living in this tension-packed atmosphere strains nerves, and tension rears its ugly head and if it becomes unbearable a risk you have to take is that only by talking out your problem can you resolve it.

This is, of course, harder if you're disabled, especially if you can't walk to speak to the person. You can't even see the person you want to see to resolve the situation.

Relying on the family also makes the solution a problem, especially if the other person is putting pride up front in the matter.

If the problem never gets resolved, both parties remain at loggerheads and for the rest of the time you live there no-one talks to each other. So where is the logic, or intelligence, in this?

We might be mad at each other for what the children have done, but the children will make up. But the parents will carry the feud forward. This not only hurts the adults but does affect the children. An attack on a person's home becomes imminent. No-one wants to leave their home. The grass is not always greener on the other side, so if you're happy with your home and your neighbours, be happy. Children will always watch their parents and will handle their problems in the same way.

Children do look up to their parents, so the message is, show them that you care for their health.

Rosemary Whiting

See or hear something suspicious? You can help stop the criminals – call

CRIMESTOPPERS

0800 555 111

CALL NOW!

PAWS FOR THOUGHT



Hello again – Summer's here! Flowers, sunshine, baby mammals and fledglings and, sadly, humans who want to destroy all these wonderful gifts of life – humans who throw stones and other objects at birds with young. Humans who callously set their "beloved" pet dogs onto beautiful young swans. I'm talking about an incident that on the last day May. Local residents were appalled to find the young swan, one of last year's fledglings, dead with its breast ripped apart, on Southmere Lake. The English are supposed to be an enlightened, civilised nation. Obviously the lightbulb has gone out for some humans and "civilised" only means they wash their hands after any bad deeds they do!

As for youngsters stoning the birds – perhaps if they were to use their brains on something like a nature ramble and realise the beauty all around them, instead of trying to reach the top level on a computer game, they would understand that it is *what is living that matters*, not animated bits of plastic!

Well now, we've had our growls for this month – on to better news.

WHO DARES WINS!

Go on! Give our annual dog show a try. All dogs are welcome, with novelty classes, breed and obedience – there is something for everyone. The show takes place on Sunday, July 8, in Southmere Park, Thamesmead. Entries from 11am. Judging starts at 12 noon. We would love to see you there. all proceeds go to the animals.

FRUITY REQUEST

If any local residents have left-over fresh fruit or vegetables, our bunnies and chipmunks would really welcome it.

COOL DUDES

Some of our residents here at the Centre rely on food which needs to be kept frozen until they require it. Unfortunately, our freezer has decided to be totally uncooperative by dispensing their food already defrosted – not good! If anyone has an old, reliable, freezer they could donate, please get in touch with us.

HELP STILL NEEDED

We still need reliable volunteers for weekend work. Is there anyone out there in li'l old Thamesmead with a few hours to spare? Strong man also wanted for short-term project (legitimate, of course!), please call us on 020 8311 5086.

FESTIVAL FEVER

Our humans raised £138.70 at the recent Erith Riverside Festival – thanks to everyone who helped on the day and special thanks to the students for sorting out jumble and helping to load and unload on the day.



STAR OF THE MONTH

This is Buddy, he desperately needs a caring home where he can be the centre of attention. He is 21 months old, a black and tan lively terrier cross, good with kids but a little apprehensive around men. He needs somewhere without other dogs or cats, where he can be someone's best buddy for life.

TAIL-ENDING

Lastly, congratulations to Hazan, one of our students, who got married in early June!

Well, that's all folk, see you next month, from the office canines Charles, Megan, Khya, Solomon, Alice and Old Man Tod.

ADVERTISERS WHO SUPPORT THE *PEOPLE* SUPPORT THE COMMUNITY'S VOICE

PROPERTY AND PLANNING



GLYNDON SHOUT



UP WITH IT WE SHALL NOT PUT!

Well it's finally over and the return of a Labour government despite the low turnout throughout the country – a disgrace, democracy is worth more than that – but at least here in Erith & Thamesmead over 50% voted and local MP John Austin was returned to Parliament with a thumping majority.

Now we can all get on with our lives but still be involved in various fora, talking with MPs, GLA members and councillors – it's important to embrace our estate management boards, to listen to people and to combine our efforts to improve life in Thamesmead.

Something that is dear to my heart is *pensions*! Great Britain has the fourth largest economy in the world. We can afford better pensions for our old 'uns. If there was a return to SERPS (State Earnings Related Pension Scheme) all our pensioners would be £30 per week better off.

It was said that the country could not afford the National Minimum Wage – but it's here and we can. So the fight for our pensions goes on. It may be a long struggle, but it's worthwhile and personally I shall not stop fighting this corner.

Here in Thamesmead, as elsewhere, nuisance neighbours are a blight on many lives. These few non-conformist neighbours playing loud music at all hours, disturbing others, don't realise that people have the right to come home to peace and quiet.

Well there is a remedy, folks. Inform the relevant authorities in Thamesmead, Greenwich and Bexley and stereo equipment can and will be confiscated, together with fines! And in more extreme cases an eviction order can be invoked.

So don't put up with it and if in doubt, contact your local councillor and something will be done.

ALAN IVES ESTATES

118 Plumstead High Street, Plumstead SE18 1SJ

Tel: 020 8854 0101



ABBEY WOOD – £119,000
3-bed hse, part d/g, gch(n/t), popular road with amenities close by. KAP0001



WOOLWICH BORDER – £115,000
3-bed eot hse, part d/g, gch(n/t), close Woolwich Common and LT! KAP0023



THAMESMEAD – £119,995
3-bed eot hse, pleasant *cul-de-sac*. Internal decor required! KAP0009



WEST THAMESMEAD – £147,000
Sp 3-bed hse, o/l Gallions Lake, sup views. D/g, gch(n/t), near amens. KAP0011



PLUMSTEAD COMMON – £149,995
Hly-mtd 3-bed hse, sup fit kit. On corner so larger. D/g, gch(n/t). KAP0017



PLUMSTEAD – £127,995
Lge 3-bed Vict hse, orig f/places/cornices. Close shops/LT. Walk to BR. KAP0020

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also at Erith on 01322 333300

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ALAN IVES TALKS ON PROPERTY

It has been well publicised before just how stressful moving house can be.

One of the worst problems is when there is a chain of several house buyers and sellers, and the buyer at the bottom of the chain pulls out leaving everyone else stranded.

Well, if you ever find yourself in this position, or if it has just happened to you, I may have the solution.

Every day we have property investors register with us with cash available ready to buy a house very quickly, provided the price is right. In the current market if a buyer pulls out a couple of months after a sale was agreed, the price previously agreed may be substantially lower than the current asking price of similar properties just coming onto the market, and similarly throughout the chain.

This means that a cash buyer may be happy to step in at the same price, as it will now seem like a bargain and the chain can be restored with the minimal loss of time. In other words, everyone gains.

So if you find yourself in that position give me a ring on 020 8854 0101 and we'll sort it out.



MORTGAGE MATTERS

By Dwain Leaver of PHS Mortgage Brokers

Everyone at some point of his or her life will experience financial hardship. For some it is more serious than others. This could lead to information being stored on your credit file which makes it difficult to gain credit.

Your credit files consist of information about you and your financial commitments, current and the previous six years. Mortgage lenders use this information and try to assess whether you are a good risk or a bad risk. This is more commonly known as credit scoring. The credit scoring system cannot be objective and works purely on facts and past history, which will mean in many cases it may work against you.

Credit scoring is a points system that allocates points for a particular item of information, eg a person living with parents might only score two points, but the same person renting a flat might score five.

At the end of the credit scoring, all your points are totalled and compared with the lender's pass mark. This will determine if you pass or fail. The pass mark is determined by the lender, which often means that because you have been declined by one lender, another may be happy to take you on.

In worst cases, you may have a default or county court judgment registered on your credit file. This will certainly have an adverse effect on your ability to gain credit, but will not stop you being able to take out a mortgage.

Some lenders will not credit score but will credit search you. This will allow access to look at your past credit history, but unlike credit scoring a human (as opposed to a computer) will look at the mortgage case objectively before giving a pass or a fail.

You can obtain your credit file by writing to Experian, PO Box 8000, Nottingham NG1 5GX and/or Equifax, PO Box 3001, Glasgow G81 2DT. You will need to enclose a cheque for £2 per person and list all the addresses that you have lived at in the last three years.

If you are having problems getting a mortgage due to a low credit score, poor credit history or county court judgments, give us a call on 020 8310 0500, we may be able to help.

Bonfires?

BLB

BEXLEY's Environmental Protection Team (020 8303 7777, ext 5146) are asking householders to be careful about bonfires – they cause neighbour problems!

Get rid of garden rubbish at Bexley's two local amenity sites: Maidstone Road, Footscray and Thames Road, Crayford. Otherwise, be friendly about bonfires!

Costly car dumping

BLB

ONE senseless act of vandalism when an abandoned car was pushed down a hill and became well and truly stuck, was dealt with by Bexley Council with a specially-made crane after the Police, Fire Brigade and even the Territorial Army were unable to help.

Unfortunately, the Council did not become aware of the existence of the abandoned red Ford Escort at Milton Road, Belvedere, until vandals had already pushed it down the steep hill, so that it became wedged at the bottom into a flight of narrow concrete steps.

It was jammed into the stairs by a rear tow bar, with the bonnet hooked under a metal handrail.

The first report reached the Highways Enforcement section on Monday, May 21, after the car had been pushed down the hill during the weekend.

It was inspected the same day and a legal notice attached saying that it would be removed for destruction if not picked up by the owner within seven days.

Because of the hazard it presented, the Council's contractor attempted to remove the vehicle on Thursday, May 24. Unfortunately, the car could not be moved with the regular equipment available. Because it was firmly wedged the car, which had been set on fire by vandals, could not simply be dragged out.

Bexley's Rangers, the Fire Brigade and the Territorial Army were approached, but were unable to help.

On Saturday, June 2, the Council hired a heavy duty crane with its operator from Beck & Pollitzer, at a cost of £340, to lift the trapped car back to road level so that it could be removed by the Council's contractor.

Residents at the North end of Milton Road were contacted and asked to keep the area clear of parked cars. Everything went ahead as planned and the offending car speedily extracted. Workmen moved in straight away to "plant" a temporary bollard at the top of the steps to prevent a similar incident. A permanent installation will follow.

Richard Stock, Bexley's assistant environmental services secretary, said "This incident highlights the substantial resources absorbed by one senseless act and also the overall problem the Council has with abandoned cars. Last year its was up to 1,156. This year we are on track for a possible 1,700 or more, which costs."



Able Estates

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PHONE 020 8306 2020
FAX: 020 8306 2010

WANTED URGENTLY
2 OR 3 BED HOUSES TO SELL

Keeping 'em down

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

THAMESMEAD was blessed by the appearance of two mobile policemen to put our 'orrible 'erberts into hiding.

On the now 10-year-old bikes this town bought (now needing replacement) they helpfully and effectively paraded our trouble spots. We thank them, and wish them well.



Photographed in the playground of Southlake School, Metropolitan Police motorcyclists PS Neil Carlton and PC Matthew Mearon

Don't be a Smoky Joe!

BLB

BARBECUES have become an enjoyable way of eating with friends during the Summer months, but they can cause a nuisance to neighbours. Smoke and noise stop them enjoying their garden and prevent them opening their windows or hanging out washing.

So, consider your neighbours when lighting your barbecue. Keep away from their property to avoid smoke going in their windows.

If you are bothered by a barbecue, approach the person concerned and explain the problem. Be friendly! They may not even be aware of causing the problem. For further advice, please contact the Environmental Protection Team on 020 8303 7777, ext 5146.

THE FIRST

with this election, the EMB members intend

You can directly elect local people to the main Gallions Housing Association Board

Now

VITAL INFORMATION

There are vacancies for five tenant members and one chargepayer member on Gallions Housing Association's management board. An election to appoint persons to fill these vacancies is to be held by postal ballot.

Tenants of the Association are eligible to appoint tenants' representatives on the board and the chargepayers are eligible to elect the chargepayers' representative. Envelopes are being delivered, addressed by name to the person(s) eligible to vote at this election. Also enclosed will be a ballot paper and declaration of identity form and those eligible should record their votes in the following manner.

There are six candidates for the five tenants' representatives' vacancies. Tenants may not vote for more than **FIVE CANDIDATES** by marking an **X** against the name(s) of the preferred candidate(s). Put no other mark on the ballot paper or it may not be counted.

The two candidates for the chargepayer vacancy are listed on the **pink** paper. The person named on the delivering envelope may vote for not more than **ONE CANDIDATE** by marking an **X** against the name of the preferred candidate. Put no other mark on the ballot paper or it may not be counted.

The marked ballot paper, together with the completed **DECLARATION OF IDENTITY** should be sent to the Returning Officer in the enclosed pre-paid envelope. To be counted, the ballot paper **must arrive by no later than 9am on Friday, June 29. NB:** any ballot papers received **without** a completed **Declaration of Identity*** **will not** be counted

* Which will be separated from the ballot papers before the count.

In a first co-operation between the members of the Gallions Housing Association Estate Management Boards and the Thamesmead People newspaper, the centre spreads of the last and this month's editions are joint promotions.

The reason for this cooperation is the firm mutual belief that the EMB members have themselves achieved an open and accountable election method that should stand as an example to others.

Gallions tenant and chargepayer board members are already working with Gallions and other EMB members, as well as outside consultants, to bring about the harmonisation of Thamesmead-wide services, under one management organisation, one telephone number, for almost all services.

The same goes for the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Safety Partnership, where tenants and Gallions' management are involved with the Police and Probation services and Bexley and Greenwich councils – looking at ways to trea the causes of crime rather than the crime.

One last thing: Gallions' chair John Fahy has set the EMBs a challenge. He has asked the EMBs to give their vision of Thamesmead in five to ten years but the EMBs think this should n be just their vision but yours, the residents of Thamesmead. Yes, a of you.

Give a little thought for the future of where we live ...



An artist's impression of the improvements to Tump 47, planned and to be executed by Groundwork and conceived by EMB members

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

CHANCE

to make democracy a good word again

CHOOSE FIVE FROM SIX

For Tenant representation



Tokky Ademoyero
tenant, EMB2
As a GHA board member, I would apply skills and experience acquired in over 20 years of government and voluntary service to community affairs. I aim to positively influence policies and strategies, and help establish a healthy rapport between the board and Thamesmead residents. I am presently chair of Ridgeway EMB



Wendy Bradbury
tenant, EMB3
Being on the board of GHA would allow me to put the views of tenants and residents to the board, helping to build a firm foundation for a good community spirit. I enjoy working for the community – as a tenant I would like to see Thamesmead become a really great place to live



Liz Gardiner
tenant, EMB3
I have lived in Thamesmead since 1978. My first voluntary job was as treasurer of Age Concern Thamesmead, which lasted 9-10 years and included becoming organiser of the Thamesmead Pop-In Parlour. I am now a member of EMB3 and a manager of the Limestone Community Hall



Terry Graves
tenant, EMB1
My aims as an EMB member and a tenant of 18 years are to improve Thamesmead and Gallions for the young and old and the disabled, by improving facilities, such as play areas, parks and meeting places, whilst keeping the area more secure, cleaner, healthier and a happier place to live!



Graham Horton
tenant, EMB3
A resident since 1986, I'm currently a GHA board member elected by EMBs, serving on the finance committee. I believe in resident involvement and have many years' experience in financial management, fifteen in the not-for-profit sector, and welcome the opportunity to use my skills for the benefit of the community



Sam Robinson
tenant, EMB1
I have lived in Thamesmead for 18 years. In that time I have represented residents in many forums and at all levels. As a sitting board member I already have training and knowledge of how to deal with and decide day-to-day issues. Vote for me and have a ready-trained board member

CHOOSE ONE FROM TWO

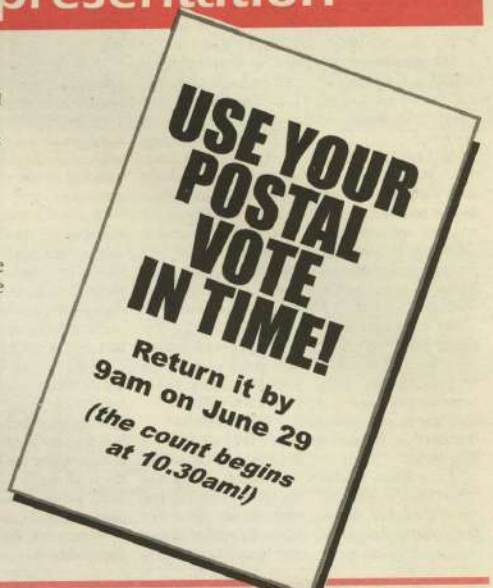
For Chargeholder/Leaseholder representation



Ray Hill
chargepayer, EMB1
I believe that one should steer or help to steer from within, that is why I joined the EMBs. I have taken an active part in all activities of the EMBs including training, which I have undergone conscientiously. As a member of the GHA board I will represent the EMBs which I believe are working hard for both residents and GHA



Kenneth Sealey
chargepayer, EMB3
I am a retired, active, married family man, a resident of 18 years, involved with the EMB and Residents' Association, serving on sub-committees, undertaking training and visits to other housing organisations. With my outlook and wide experience of the locality, I believe I have the necessary qualifications to be on the GHA board



WE CAN MAKE IT WORK, TOGETHER

YOU CAN HAVE A SAY IN THE TOMORROWS OF THAMESMEAD







Money from the CITY

PRESS RELEASE

AN innovative scheme that was kick-started by CITY (Construction Industry Training for Youth) has grown into a highly successful training and employment project.

Five years ago CITY donated £20,000 to Thamesmead Town Ltd – now Trust Thamesmead Ltd – to help young people develop their skills and break into the construction industry. The money was used to match young unemployed people to the right training as well as providing basic tools and equipment and helping them with the cost of travelling to interviews and work.

Some of the cash was also used to subsidise employers who took on apprentices or young people who had recently qualified.

Thanks to CITY funding, Trust Thamesmead has been able to support more than 100 people. Some have been found apprenticeships in plumbing, carpentry, bricklaying and scaffolding.

Others have improved and upgraded existing skills, working with bodies like the Construction Industry Training Board and Bexley College.

Many of those people have since gone on to find permanent employment with local firms, including Wilcon, Wimpey, Persimmons, Barratts, B&B Construction, Total Construction and Keith Longman Electricals.

Since the CITY grant, the Trust Thamesmead scheme – now called StepUp – has mushroomed into a valued job-training project. To date, StepUp has helped 800 people and 72% of them have gone on to find permanent work.

StepUp's Janice Piotrowski said "CITY were the first trust to provide us with financial support for young people who wanted to develop construction industry skills. It demonstrates what a real difference a grant can make to a training scheme like this – and to people's lives."

Thamesmead has historically been an unemployment black spot. But government and European money combined with support from groups like CITY has enabled StepUp to find training and work for many unemployed people in the area.

Following the success of the project, CITY has awarded the Trust an additional £6,000 to continue to support young people into the construction industry.



The cheque presentation this month in the Trust offices: CITY's Doug Barratt handing the £6,000 cheque over to the Trust's Julian Martin and Janice Piotrowski

It's your dog's holiday too!

BATTERSEA DOGS' HOME

Holidays? What about the pooch?

MAKE the proper arrangements and put your dog at the top of your Summer holiday checklist – remember, it's your dog's holiday too!

Here are a few pointers to help you make sure your dog enjoys a relaxing and refreshing break while you are away.

SELECTING A KENNEL

Book early! Kennels, just like the best hotels, are always busy and under pressure during the peak holiday season, especially during school holidays, so book in advance.

But how do you recognise the best?

1. *Word of mouth*. A recommendation from someone you know is a great starting point. Ask a friend/vet/dog trainer for their opinion.

2. *The Recce*. Visit the kennel and check the following: a, is it clean, tidy and in a good state of repair?; b, do the current guests appear happy?; c, how many walking excursions do the dogs get a day (at least two!)?; d, what are the rooms like (each dog should have its own run area)? and c, can your dog take something familiar from home – a blanket or favourite toy?

3. *Vaccination history*. The kennel should always ask to see evidence of each dog's vaccination records. A good one will always insist!

4. *Holiday insurance*. The kennel should have comprehensive insurance. If a vet has to be called, the insurance should cover the expense.

For further information on selecting a kennel, visit www.dogsonline.co.uk.

THE SELF-CATERING OPTION

If your dog prefers the flexibility of home catering, then this option is for him. Dog sitters can take care of your dog in the comfort of your own home. Alternatively, they can take your dog into their home – the choice is yours.

How to find the perfect dog sitter.

1. *Word of mouth*. A personal recommendation is always a very good start.

2. *The local paper*. Most dog sitters are independent and tend to advertise in the classified section of local newspapers.

3. *The interview*. Any reputable dog sitter worth their salt will happily meet you and your dog for an interview. Decide, with your dog, whether you like this person and are prepared to trust them in your home.

4. *References*. Always ask for references and follow them up.

Once you've found your ideal dog sitter you will need to discuss your dog's holiday requirements – walks, meals, personal treats and pampering needs, *etc*.

Remember, it's your dog's holiday too.

If your dog is being taken into the dog sitter's home, ensure that he gets on with all of his new temporary family, particularly other pets/small children.

For further information contact the National Association of Registered Dog Sitters, who hold a central register and can provide a list of suitable contacts in your area. They can be reached on 01584 711534, at info@dogsitters.co.uk or take a look at their website at www.dogsit.net.

If your dog is lucky enough to stay with friends or relatives, make sure they are well prepared for their guest's needs by taking note of the following points: use the faithful pooper scooper; keep your dog on his lead in public areas and guard against open windows and doors through which the dog might stray.

Finally, make sure you have a temporary collar disc made, displaying the name and contact number of your dog's carer – this can be done quickly and cheaply. Also, remember to leave emergency contact details, including your vet's name, address and telephone number, just in case. Happy holidays!

The ceremony of the Constable's Dues

PRESS RELEASE

EVERY large Royal Navy ship that visits the Port of London delivers a barrel of rum to the Governor of the Tower of London, on Tower Green, in a ceremony known as the Constable's Dues.

This happens around once a year and is a reminder of the once more extensive perquisites enjoyed by past Constables.

There are documented accounts of the dues paid to the Constable of the Tower from the fourteenth century onwards. However, the custom is thought to pre-date even this period.

Every ship that came upstream to the City had to moor at Tower Wharf to unload a portion of its cargo for the Constable and thus enjoy the protection of the Tower of London guns.

In the past, such bounty included oysters, mussels, cockles, rushes and wine.

This tradition is still upheld in the Ceremony of the Constable's Dues. When the Royal Navy moors one of its ships alongside the Tower, the captain of the vessel delivers a barrel of rum to the Constable as a symbol of those ancient rights.

Accompanied by an escort of Yeoman Warders in state dress and a corps of drums, the captain and his escort of Naval ratings march through the Tower of London to Tower Green, where the ceremony takes place.

A colourful custom, it is re-enacted each year and the participants usually retire to Queen's House afterwards to sample the contents.

It is free to anyone who has paid their entrance fee and is visiting the Tower on the day.

Formerly, in the absence of the Sovereign at the Tower of London, the Constable would have been one of the most powerful men in the City.

As well as being one of the most honourable positions in the Crown's service, it was also one of the most profitable.

Perks of the job included any horses, oxen, pigs or sheep that fell off London Bridge. For every foot of livestock that stumbled into the Tower moat, the Constable received a penny and any cart that fell in became his property.

The Constable was entitled to demand 6s 8d (35p) a year from the owners of all boats fishing for sprat between the Tower and the sea; 1s (5p) a year from all ships carrying herring to London and 2d (2p) from each pilgrim who came to London by sea to worship at the shrine of St James.

Unfortunate circumstances require us urgently to seek someone to replace our delivery person, to deliver the *Abbey Wood and Thamesmead People* to these roads (either side of Yarnton Way) each month

Wolvercote, Lensbury, Hinksey, Coralline, Binsey, Hartslock, Seacourt, Portmeadow and the Saints

Please contact Rosemarie, between 9am and 5pm on **020 8473 0128**

See or hear something suspicious? You can help stop the criminals – call

CRIMESTOPPERS 0800 555 111

CALL NOW!



All this gadding about – new things at pubs and clubs to see and enjoy and the Summer's here too! Can't be bad. But take a look at the pictures of Lin's new hairstyle on the next page – now that's what I call just a tad adventurous. Next thing she'll be seen Bungee jumping in Birchmere Park for the Festival. The things that gal will do to raise charity money! This town's just never dull, is it?

THE LEATHER BOTTLE



131 Heron Hill
Belvedere DA17 5HJ
01322 432066

Built in 1648, the attractive old Dutch barn is now run as a family pub. It has air conditioning and its restaurant seats 170

Dave and Sylvia Allen welcome families to the Leather Bottle's Traditional Sunday Roast, from 1 to 4.30 (children half price) – and enjoy our beautiful gardens. Business lunches: open daily

Chubby Brown's

FORMERLY STEVE'S CAFE TELEPHONE 020 8310 2430

LIME ROW AND YARNTON WAY, THAMESMEAD, ERITH

The cafe with community involvement – open from 7 to 2, Mon-Fri, Sat 8am-2pm

Good food for working men and women
For families, for mums and kids and for pensioners
Catering to local businesses with a fine delivery service
Parties and buffets – taking the provision out into the town

Chubby Brown's

The Belfry Club



100 Plumstead High Street, SE18 1SJ • Tel **020 8855 5368**

The Belfry, for an easy social life with all the comforts of home, including hot snacks. Sky sports on two big screens, with resident darts, crib, pool and football teams, plus club events. *For membership, talk to Jim McDonnell*

The Dashwood Club

No bus
No cab
No bother
Just walk in

Alternating Friday Nights: Race Nights and Live music
Plus the Sunday Sea-food lunches and roast spuds on the bar

Membership renewals/applications coming up soon – see Tony

Limestone Walk, Thamesmead **020 8311 7765**

THE BARGEPOLE

Harrow Manor Way Tel 020 8312 4943

come on in for the craic!

Sunday afternoons - live music
Sunday evenings - Pool knockout - CASH Prizes
MONDAY CLUB – Over 18s only
TUESDAY QUIZ NIGHTS – Cash prizes and surprises
Friday nights – Katts Disco
Saturdays – Live music/Disco

The WELCOMING LOCAL

JOLLY MARSHMAN



Bringing the good old days back to Abbey Wood

Easily accessible, with free car parking ...

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Telephone **020 8310 8883**



TELEPHONE 020 8311 0780

THE LAKESIDE COMPLEX

Function Hall/Night Club for hire, as well as 220-seat Restaurant (overlooking the Lake) for parties, weddings, christenings etc

Fridays Karaoke 2am closing Thursdays, Fridays and Saturdays



Sunday Carvery
12 noon to 4pm, from
£4.95
per head (adults)

LAKESIDE CHARCOAL GRILL
Telephone
020 8312 2313
Opening times
Sunday to Thursday 5pm–11pm
Friday and Saturday 5pm–12pm
£8 minimum order for FREE delivery (or £1 fee), up to 3.5 miles for free delivery

Goodies on the night

UNITY

Dress to impress

U18s Disco held at Archie's Night Club
Friday, June 29
7.30–11.45
any youngster or parent needing information, contact Wayne on 07980 482404

NEW OPENING!

Back to '89 **Archie's** Back to '89
NIGHT CLUB
Over 21s
Opening July 27
DRESS TO IMPRESS
No caps or trainers

2 BELVEDERE ROAD • THAMESMEAD • LONDON SE2 9AN



Lin as she dressed for the skinhead, bovver-boy part – *with* her golden locks



The bald bovver gal – light on top but highly successful

Bovver gal at the Cutty!

Lin at the Cutty Sark pub, Thamesmead town centre, raises £1,620

Well everybody had to see that. Lin's golden curls were going to be chopped, by Peter, for charity!

This month, Lin and Peter had heard of a regular who needed help, so they came up with the idea of putting Lin through a sponsored head-shave!

It seemed clear to me that many of the ladies present didn't really think Lin would go through with it, and their expressions as Peter wielded the trimmers made quite a picture!

Wield them he did and fairly effectively – safely too, there wasn't much blood about (although Lin counted her ears as she stood up!) so they were able to stand down the paramedics.

Those of you who know her will know that once Lin sets her mind to a job she gets it done. This one was. Done.

She had been circulating beforehand with flagon in hand to collect the sponsorship money from a crowded pub and people gave willingly.

Keeping careful note of everything (they do things properly in the Cutty) they eventually summed the total: for one evening an incredible £1,620!

The collection was handed over to the beneficiary's representative in the pub on the night of June 18.

Now, very importantly, Lin is wearing her new hair style with pride. No hiding (well, she was never a shy lady) although she's not in jeans and braces any more!



To the horror of the watching women, Pete gets barbering while the crowd goes silent – for a little while!



By now the damage is done – and Pete's getting nervous!

Elsewhere, things are happening too. The **Birchwood**'s Caribbean Christmas is on at the same time as the talent show in the C2K Club, so I'll have to bounce between the two. I suppose it'll be more like a crawl, but we'll see.

But I've certainly got to sample Jane's Caribbean dishes – and everyone's wondering how Martin's going to dress?

I did manage a trip to Plumstead and called in at the **Belfry Club** on a lovely sunny lunchtime – having a toasted sandwich with my pint (very good too).

Little Chloe, now walking, is of course tiring Jim and Debbie out, but when I called she was sleeping off her last excursion so didn't disturb anyone. I almost settled in there, it was so comfortable.

I didn't though. I managed a slow amble up the road to the **Plume of Feathers**, being lucky enough to catch landlady Sue there, running a busy lunchtime.

I couldn't manage my usual cheese and onion sandwich there because I'd eaten at the Belfry – can't have everything, can you?

I've been chatting to a young man who's attended the Unity dance evenings for young people at the **Lakeside Complex** – he spoke very well of it. If that's any indication of how they'll be running things in the new Archie's night club there then it should be a first-rate facility.

Wayne tells me the new night club's named after his young son.

There's welcome talk of other bodies using the facilities at the Lakeside more – a kick-off is a meeting/conference of Gallions EMBs in the offing. Good luck to the lads there, they deserve success.

And no, I didn't get to see Debbie at the **Jolly Marshman**. Well I got near, when I was at the Plume, but my mate Roy tells me that he made it there and everything's tickety-boo, so fine.

Once this edition's out of my hands I'm going to enjoy some of this warm weather and probably get down to **Chubby Brown**'s eatery for a long-delayed damn good fry-up breakfast. Or, as Rosemarie tells me, naughty but nice!

I think I shall need some recuperation after that and after all, I've got to prepare myself for this up-coming festival, so I can see some very committed snooze-time in the armchair coming up.

Thanks to everybody who helped me this month, by chauffering me places, covering for me, waiting for me, ringing me – generally covering for a lazy old fart. Rosemarie said I'd better thank you all or I'd have further to walk next month.

I'll try to figure that one out, meanwhile, enjoy the coming warm, eventful days.



THE BIRCHWOOD
The neighbourhood pub for the family and for business – for the close evening out or for the secluded business lunch



Dermot Hegarty's back! July 6

July 14
LYN (vocalist)
July 21
STEVE WILLIAMS
Music from the 60s, 70s, 80s, 90s

Business lunches all week.
Function Room available without charge
Where the Royal British Legion meets

Grovebury Road, Abbey Wood, SE2 9BB **020 8312 4867**

Greenmead AFC

WAYNE BALDACCHINO

WITH only four games to go it was a nerve-wracking last two weeks of the season. Steven Nicola and Adam Craig gave us a 2–0 win over Welling before the big one, Darenth Rangers, who were top.

There was excellent support frpom parents on both sidelines and the game was a cracker. Both teams had good chances to take the lead but some excellent defending from Dave Tarrant, David O'Dwyer and Darren O'Loughlin in the Greenmead defence kept the door shut.

Allen Gobbett was missing with a broken wrist and will unfortunately miss the rest of the season.

Greenmead completely dominated the second half but could not make the breakthrough.

Come on down, Lee Sugden. With just two minutes of the game to go, Sugsie scored a great, curling free kick from 25 yards to give the Finches maximum points and top spot.

Never miond Darenth, better luck next time.

On the Tuesday night we had a good 3–0 home win over Hextable. Sam Whittington scored two, Brendan Mulvaney getting the third.

One game to go and at least one point required. Nerves were showing and a great Phoenix display kept us on a knife edge. Although we went 1–0 up Phoenix put us under pressure and equalised with a great strike. We missed a few sitters late on – but the point was enough and crowned us U16 B East League Winners

I am extremely proud of the whole squad as this is no easy League to win. They were excellent all season, with a first-class attitude and excellent discipline.

Our record read played 20, won 15, drew 3, lost 2, goals for 80, goals against 19, points 33, goal difference +61.

We can now relax and enjoy the Summer 5-a-side toournaments we have entered. We are in four during June before the July break. I am sure there will also be the usual shuffle of players during the Summer, especially at this age group. We are probably looking at four out and four in. At least two defenders are a priority for us.

PRESENTATION AWARD WINNERS

EUROPA Player of the Year: Sam Whittington
Parents' Player: Lee Sugden
Players' Player: David O'Dwyer
Chairman's Award: Darren O'Loughlin
Most Consistent Player: Allen Gobbett
Most Sporting Player: Brendan Mulvaney
100 League/Cup Appearances: Brendan Mulvaney
200 League/Cup appearances: Allen Gobbett, Sean Cross, Andrew Johnson and Darren O'Loughlin

At the time of writing we had reached two finals in the 5-a-sides. We won the Kingfisher Tournament and came runners-up in the Phoenix Tournament.

U16 Squad: Mattie Keehne, Andrew Johnson, David O'Dwyer, Dave Tarrant, Lee Sugden, Allen Gobbett, Sean Cross, Darren O'Loughlin, Tony O'Brien, Adam Craig, Steven Nicola, James Jones, Brendan Mulvaney, David Bacon, Sam Whittington and John Gallagher. Manager, Wayne Baldacchino.

Top response to benefits take-up campaign

BLB

A campaign backed by Bexley Council to encourage pensioners to take up the full Income Support to which they are entitled has proved a great success.

During the telephone campaign in April, the hotline at Thamesmead Law Centre received more than 130 calls – and 92 were identified as being entitled to receive Income Support. Claim packs are being sent to the callers.

Some are already receiving more money as a result and others are being helped to fill in forms through home visits. The campaign identified 11 clients who are also entitled to receive Attendance Allowance or Disability Allowance.

The campaign is being run by Age Concern, in conjunction with the Thamesmead Law Centre, Bexley Council and Capita Business Services, and the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Chest.

Age concern also dealt with other clients who called into their offices after they wrote to elderly people in the Thamesmead area.

Government figures showed that four out of ten pensioners entitled to Income Support do not claim it. A check by Thamesmead Law Centre found that 19 out of 100 pensioners in one block in Thamesmead were not getting all the benefits to which they were entitled.

Thamesmead Law Centre is working for everyone, regardless of age, to ensure that people get the benefits to which they are entitled.

BBD NEWS
3 PICARDY STREET
BELVEDERE DA17 5QQ
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newsagents
confectioners
tobacconists
greetings cards *and*
newspaper deliveries -
and the
Thamesmead People

THE ABBEY WOOD & THAMESMEAD **PEOPLE** is entering its eighth year of service to this community

So we must be doing something right, mustn't we?



Thamesmead Community Forum

2-6 Griffin Manor Way
West Thamesmead Business Park
Thamesmead SE28 0AB
Telephone 020 8854 0306
e-mail forum@respondbank.co.uk

The Thamesmead Community Forum gives the community a voice to access decision-making processes that affect them.
By becoming involved in the Community Forum, you can have a say in how the community develops in the new millennium.
The Community Forum is responsive to local issues and local needs.

What does the Community Forum do?

* Gives local people a voice in the development of their area
* Promotes the principle of partnership as the best way of making change happen for the benefit of all
* Works with the Council and Business Forum to obtain sustainable development
* Explores new ideas, initiatives and projects
* Acts as a focal point enabling the sharing of ideas and as a major resource and source of information on funding and regeneration issues
* Provides information for skills development to individual groups and members
* Facilitates the development of Community Forums throughout the borough.

It's your community, so why not get involved?

Introducing Andrea

PEOPLE EDITORIAL



THE Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Safety Partnership announced in these pages in a previous edition, has a primary operator to research and implement policies to improve life in our area. She may be contacted at the Gallions Housing Association's offices. Her name is Andrea Kilvington – and she introduces herself.

"I was born and brought up in the Bexley area and went to school at what is now Townley Grammar. I went on to train in engineering as a designer.

"I spent a number of years involved in engineering as a project manager acquiring degree level qualifications in business and management studies, before returning to full time education to study towards my current area of work.

"I acquired a Socio-legal degree at the University of Greenwich and enjoyed it so much that I went on to study for a Master of Science degree at the London School of Economics, passing with distinction in Criminal Justice Policy.

"Since qualifying, I spent a short time lecturing and then went on to do research and development work for a variety of different organisations including the Home Office, Prison Service and a variety of voluntary organisations involved in working with criminal justice agencies.

"I am very happily married and my husband has a business in the borough of Bexley. We don't have our own children yet, but I have two adorable nephews who are 4 and 5 but who sadly now live in the States.

"Nevertheless, we try to see them as often as possible as we miss them terribly. On the rare occasions that I get the opportunity, I am a keen (but not necessarily good) golfer and tennis player and also enjoy my garden.

"My post is sponsored by Gallions but I am employed by the Greenwich Community Safety Trust to support the partnership in the Thamesmead and Abbey Wood area.

"I aim to work hard for the community here, using all of my experience to help develop initiatives that will tackle local problems or concerns related to crime and anti-social behaviour across the SRB4 area.

"I want people to be assured that behind the scenes I am working in partnership with other projects and agencies, to improve community safety, promoting their interests as far as possible."

In The Beginning

A DIARY OF EVENTS IN THAMESMEAD

1965 – Greater London Council [GLC] draws up plans to build a new town to house 48,000 Londoners on the 1,300 acre site of Belvedere and Erith marshes and the vacant Royal Ordinance Factory land.

1966 – Main contract to build Areas 1, 2, 3a and 3d awarded to Holland Hannen & Cubitts at a cost of £30 million pounds. Foundation piling sub-contract to sink 37,000 piles at a cost of £750,000 given to West Piling Ltd.

1967 – January. Start of foundations and groundwork at Coralline Walk. The name "Thamesmead" was submitted by Anthony Walton of Barnhurst, Kent, to a competition run by the *Kentish Times* and the *Mercury* at the request of the GLC.

1968 – January. A Balency industrialised building system factory to supply concrete panels for the first stages of Thamesmead began production near the Woolwich Industrial Estate, Nathan Way.

April. Dr Peter Higgins with fellow practitioner Dr Christopher Schilling set up the community's first health centre in a temporary building in Lensbury Way, until the permanent centre is completed on Tavy Bridge podium deck.

June. Cost of building Thamesmead estimated at £211 million pounds.

July 3. Thamesmead's first tenants Terence and Joan Gooch, their two sons John and Tony and daughter Vilia move into 2 Coralline Walk from Peckham, South East London. On arrival they are presented with a commemorative plaque to mark the occasion by Desmond Plummer, Chairman of the Greater London Council – also present was the newly appointed Thamesmead community officer David Llewellyn. The GLC also housed its key workers on Coralline Walk. Resident caretaker Mr Brown and resident heating engineers Ronnie Stuckey with his wife Mary and Peter Dray with his wife Carol and their children, at 1, 7 and 9 Coralline Walk respectively.

February 14. The next families to arrive in Thamesmead were Jim and Susan Murray with son and daughter Kenneth and Rose, and John and Viv Clark with son and daughter Dean and Jacqueline. They move into 109 and 111 Coralline Walk on the upper level.

February 21. Thamesmead's first vicar, the Reverend Patrick Forbes with his wife Annette and son Stephen, move into 4 Coralline Walk. Thereafter there was a steady flow of pioneers arriving day by day.

1969 June. Abbey Primary School opened in Lensbury Way. Head Teacher Mr Roach. Local children previously attended Picardy School, Belvedere.

June 11. The Thamesmead Community Association [TCA] formed in the GLC Information Centre, Harrow Manor Way.

August 1. Old People's Dwellings at Evenlode House opened. First senior citizens to take up residence: Mr and Mrs Gamble, Miss Davis and Mrs Hetty Hanlon.

September 15. First families move into Binsey Walk.

September. Survey by Miss Claire Chisholm of first 48 households in Thamesmead.

October. Clewer House, Wolvercote Road, officially opened by then Sir Desmond Plummer, leader of the GLC.

November 7. Jim Wellbeloved, MP for Erith & Crayford, campaigns for Thames Flood Barrier to be sited at Crayfordness to protect Thamesmead.

November. First residents move into town houses in Lensbury Way.

December 18. Rev Patrick Forbes produces three editions of Thamesmead's first newsletter "Mesmedaath".

December. Maplin House opened for occupation.

Trolleybuses, trams or plain vanilla buses?

GLA

LEN DUVALL, Greater London Authority member for Greenwich & Lewisham, welcomed the pending launch of the consultation about and into the Greenwich Waterfront Transit and he urged people to take part in the consultation process.

The Waterfront Transit is a new kind of public transport scheme for South East London.

The proposed route runs from North Greenwich Station through to Abbey Wood, taking in Woolwich Road, Woolwich town centre, the Royal Arsenal site and Thamesmead (West, central and South).

It would use lanes separate from other traffic and would be given priority at road junctions so that journeys would be quicker and suffer fewer delays.

Part of the consultation process covers asking what type of vehicle would best be suited to the Transit – bus, tram or trolleybus.

"Over the past decade a rising population, increasing employment and growing tourism have dramatically increased the demands on London's transport system," said Len Duvall. "The Transit would provide a high-quality, environmentally-friendly service. There could be convenient interchanges with existing rail and bus services and it will provide an easily accessible, comfortable journey with shorter journey times."

Consultation is also starting on the East London Transit. This links in with the Waterfront Transit, assuming the proposed Thames Gateway Bridge is built.



Seeing the works in progress are, left to right: Cllr John Fahy, Chair of Gallions Housing; Rita Edney, local resident and Ridgeway EMB; John Austin, Erith and Thamesmead MP; Huw Crompton, Groundwork; Ambrose Gillham, Headteacher, Bishop John Robinson Primary School and Alistair Macleod, Groundwork

Manorway Green

PRESS RELEASE

Works begins installing new play facilities at Manorway Green, Thamesmead

IMPROVEMENTS proposed for Manorway Green, Thamesmead have now begun, thanks to the local environmental regeneration charity Groundwork, Gallions Housing, Rideway Estate Management Board and Greenwich Council.

The facelift includes an imaginative new play area for children under 12, together with improved lighting, footpaths and seating.

The play area is being built in the middle of "tump 47", a filled-in old amphitheatre, and will be surrounded by wooden fencing styled like a fort.

A colourful wooden bridge will lead into the play area where there will be swings, a roundabout, a slide, climbing frame and a see-saw and finished off with bright safety surfacing.

SAFETY

New paths will be cut into the hillock or tump to improve the visibility, allowing children to play in safety.

The park is a result of considerable consultation with local residents and the local Bishop John Robinson primary school.

Alistair Macleod, Groundwork's community projects officer, said "the play area should be superb, it combines safety with exciting play facilities for young children."

Works began at the beginning of May and will be completed in mid July. Once finished, the facilities will be officially opened with a fun filled celebration event.

The improvements are funded from Groundwork's Single Regeneration Fund and Gallions Housing Association.

To oversee the improvements and contribute towards the long term management of the park, a user group has now been set up. All local residents are welcome to join, for further information, contact Alistair Macleod on 020 8691 8002.

Consider this . . .

I was approached by two local people I respect and asked to look at assisting a man who had an idea. This is the idea. Consider what he has to say ...

INTRODUCTION

The benefits of healthy living have been well documented for many years.

Although much effort has gone into making people more aware of these benefits, a large proportion of the population are still unable to make use of conventional fitness programmes provided by local authority fitness centres.

This is largely due to social exclusion and cost.

These groups include, but are not limited to, those on low incomes including unemployed, lone parent families, those employed in low paying jobs, ethnic minority groups, women, young people, disabled (mentally and physically) or young offenders.

We are a group of health and fitness professionals who are dedicated to bringing the benefits of healthy living to a wider audience.

We believe that although individuals are now becoming more aware of the health benefits associated with keeping fit, many of these benefits are offset by the cost, travel time or lack of facilities.

There is also a general shortage of high calibre fitness professionals with up to date motivational skills and the ability to reach minority groups.

The Community Fitness project is designed to overcome these barriers.

We are seeking to provide a non-profit making structure in which health and fitness trainers would take mobile fitness services out into the community.

This means that we would be able to visit local groups, youth centres, community halls and old peoples' homes and actually take healthy living into their environment.

As a group we have a great deal of experience in providing these services to international companies on a commercial basis.

This can be seen by visiting the business website at www.fullforcefitness.co.uk.

We do however believe that with a small amount of funding, the provision of equipment (donated by us) and a committed staff force, this community fitness project would be able to provide a measurable benefit to combat disaffection within any London borough.

HOW WOULD IT WORK?

Listed below are a few examples of how the service would operate: Imagine a group of mothers who drop off their children at the local nursery in the morning.

The fact that there is already a group of people gathered in one place means that we would simply provide an instructor and the equipment to facilitate an aerobics, dance or other exercise class.

Due to the travel time and expense many mothers would not be able to find the time out of their day to partake in such classes.

Many young people who become involved in crime, attribute boredom and a lack of facilities as contributing factors.

We are able to provide a wide range of fitness coaches in various disciplines.

We can go to where the people are and provide activities that they actually want.

The disciplines involved in taking up sport have literally rescued many youngsters from a life of crime.

We can help them to step off the street and become a part of something constructive within their neighbourhood.

We would also be able to set them the goal of perhaps qualifying to become an instructor.

We currently have an instructor who teaches seated aerobics in a nursing home for the elderly twice a week.

Many of the people in the home are unable to go out and spend many hours sitting, reading and watching television.

Up to thirty people at a time take part in the sessions and they all say it's the highlight of their week.

We have a female instructor who is of Indian origin. She conducts a circuit training class twice a week.

The class is held for Hindu women who have a certain dress code and are not permitted to join in mixed fitness sessions.

One facet of healthy living, which is often overlooked, is educating people about the benefits before they develop bad habits.

We would be looking to go out to schools/colleges to give practical talks and presentations on subjects such as smoking, healthy eating and the role of exercise in maintaining a healthy body.

STAFFING THE PROJECT

It is envisaged that we would aim to recruit local fitness instructors who could demonstrate both a high level of proficiency and a commitment to their local community.

Priority would be given to instructors who could show that they have already been involved in some type of community initiative.

Each instructor would be required to have the necessary level of qualification for their field, adequate insurance cover, current first aid certificate and police checks for those working with young children.

Although we already have access to over twenty instructors who meet these criteria we would prefer to use instructors local to the area of activity.

We believe that such people will have a better understanding of their own community.

As part of the community project we would also seek to employ at least one young person each year as a trainee fitness instructor.

In addition to providing this person with a recognised instructor training qualification, we would also provide on the job training.

It is envisaged that this person would eventually be able to conduct their own groups within their area.

Individuals in our team have been involved in the fitness industry for over fifteen years.

We have a large network of instructors who can be called upon to provide support in areas where local instructors are not available.

We are therefore able to offer a unique range of services to suit the specific needs of any group.

FUNDING THE PROJECT

As a group we would be willing to let the project have free use of our extensive range of mobile fitness equipment, worth over £15,000.

We are currently looking for additional parties to sponsor or fund the project in terms of providing means of transport and fees for instructors.

Local newspapers and radio stations could be persuaded to promote the service within their area as a provision for the community.

Since it would bring a benefit to the area in general, we also believe that local companies could also play a part by sponsoring sports kits for teams or groups in the area.

We believe that certain areas would see a drop in crime if youngsters were provided with workable alternatives, groups such as the crime prevention schemes would be seen in a favourable light if they took some proactive steps to reduce crime in their area.

We feel that this is a community project that has the potential to produce a lasting benefit within the areas it is adopted.

Much funding seems to be channelled into providing buildings which are seldom used and paying for administration of projects rather than people who are actually carrying them out.

This is a real opportunity to tap into people in their community who are passionate about health and fitness and have a strong sense of commitment towards the improvement of their neighbourhood.

Ed: There were pictures with the original, longer, article, which has been edited down.

This Project is, I feel, better considered by a wider audience than just me. Interested readers will be able to touch base at the web site

respect

a free anti-racist and multicultural festival for London

Venue: Finsbury Park, London
Date: Saturday 21 July 2001
Time: midday-8.30pm
Tickets: free - no tickets required
Enquiries: 020 7983 6554
Web: www.respectfestival.org.uk
Email: info@respectfestival.org.uk

Acts so far confirmed:

Main stage: Run DMC, Ben Onono, sam state of bengal, Joi, Ms Dynamite, Courtney Pine

Bread and Roses Stage: Sonar Fly, Motimba, Bap Kennedy, Eustad Shaggan

Dance Stage: Danza Libre, Saneko, Grupo da Amaru

Comedy tent: Rudi Lickwood, Gina Yashere, Junior Simpson, Stephen K Amos, Paul Chowdhry, Roy Diamond, Andrew Murrell, K Walker, Patrice O'Neal, Jocelyn Jee

...with more to follow...

- respect is the first major event to be organised by the Greater London Authority. It is being organised in conjunction with the National Assembly against Racism (NAAR) and the TUC South East and Eastern Region (SERTUC). It revives earlier respect festivals that took place in 1996 and 1997 and the plan is for it to become an annual event
- Choice FM will be broadcasting live from their own stage, with DJs and special guests. Other sponsors that have confirmed their support include Lipton's Ice, who will be organising beach volley ball inside their marquee, and the Bread & Roses public house, who will feature performances from a stage as part of their bar
- Windfield, a partnership between the Mean Fiddler Organisation and the Workers' Beer Company, have been contracted by the GLA to organise the festival

New formula for performance

PRESS RELEASE

THE new Piaggio MC^3 offers so much more than before. More power, more performance and more fun in the Summer sun. Building on the legacy of its predecessor the NRG MC^2, the MC^3 remains faithful to the NRG tradition of offering the best performance in the highly competitive 50cc Super-Sport market, making it the ideal choice for aspiring racers.

Two sporty models are available for 2001, the air-cooled DT and the liquid cooled DD. The latter is fitted with the PRO version of the HiPer 2 engine, specially developed for the MC^3 by Piaggio's engine division.

Equipped with serpentine racing muffler, two-stage catalytic converter and secondary air system (SAS), the MC^3 DD has the acceleration and pick-up to outperform all other 50cc scooters. Piaggio has also made sure that safety is paramount with a 220mm disc brake at the front and a 175mm disc brake at the rear on the DD and a solid 110mm drum on the DT version, making sure that the MC^3 stops as well as it goes.

The MC^3 has also been re-styled to give it the appearance to match the performance. Several racing elements have been added, such as the carbon-look front mudguard, rear spoiler and instrumentation with round dials in tinted aluminium. Features that return the MC^3 to its commuter role include a comfortable seat and large space under it, as well as the flat footrest space (the largest in the sports scooter market sector).

From now until September 30, the Piaggio NRG MC^3 DD and DT are even better value as Piaggio is offering 50% off the cost of third party fire and theft insurance on selected models on premiums up to £400.

This package on certain models is available to all riders in all areas.

For more information, readers should call Piaggio on 0800 20 30 10 and quote reference FP068.



Bexley College is running a programme of FREE taster/introductory sessions over June and July, at places chosen for your convenience here in town. Courses include

Assertiveness training • First aid • Self defence • Welfare rights and benefits • Living for one • New opportunities for women • Junior sports leader award • Working in a team • Child protection • Negotiation skills • Advocacy • Electronics • Business studies • Massage • Leisure and tourism • Nutrition • Anger/stress management • Interview techniques • CV writing • Volunteering in your community • Parenting • Health and hygiene • Equal opportunities • Listening skills • Sales techniques • Communication skills • Ready for employment • Aromatherapy • Retail • Makeup/personal care

Talk to Francoise Sillett at Trust Thamesmead 020 8320 4470

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Mixing arts

PEOPLE EDITORIAL

ROGER and Paul, the partners at Bang On Arts, down beside Plumstead Bus garage, have both business and creativity to look after.

With art tuition classes covering many forms of painting and sculpture being booked, the creative and practical side of candle-making blossoms too.

BUGS

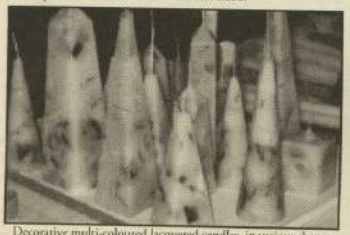
Few are aware of how the bugs that bedevil barbecues can be kept at bay simply by the lighting of one of Bang On's special candles.

Even fewer know how to make candles for both practical and decorative uses. Well, you can take classes in doing that too at Bang On. Of course you can buy candles there – now the word's got out Roger and Paul get quite a few telephone interruptions to their cuppas!

If readers have an interest in the arts they should give the lads a ring and fix to go see them – there's much more to discover there than can be summarised here.

They run set classes in subjects that fit with the demands of a varied range of clients and can be quite accommodating when it comes to times of the day. The production of candles (and the tuition linked with that) is naturally linked to matters like the time it takes to melt wax, *etc*, but it all fits together.

It's a friendly set-up, give them a ring. Talk candles, painting and sculpture, or perspective, media and colours, or waxes and perfumes – check their advertisement on page 2.



Decorative multi-coloured lacquered candles, in various shapes



A whole lot of halleluyahs – producing church candles is a thriving business at Bang On



Anti-bug candles – making garden barbecues less itchy!

Bexley's badland draft readied

BLB

BEXLEY Council is well prepared for the Government's new contaminated land regime.

The Government recently required councils all over the country to publish a strategy to tackle contaminated land. Bexley's draft Contaminated Land Strategy has recently been approved for public consultation.

It details how the Council will prioritise the investigation and, where necessary, the restoration of land that may have been contaminated by past industrial activities.

Bexley will oversee contaminated land restoration as lead regulator, with support from other organisations such as the Environmental Agency.

The Council expects to co-operate closely with organisations that take a proactive approach to dealing with the legacy of contamination. It may, however, take enforcement action where it appears that a polluter is not dealing with matters effectively.

Bexley hopes that fostering good relationships between developers, landowners and community representatives will encourage greater development of contaminated land. This will help meet the Government's targets for the sustainable use and regeneration of "brown field" sites.

Ed: readers might like to note this announcement along with the "Thamesmead Conscience" column on the back page.

POST BAG

Address letters to **The Editor, The Thamesmead People, 5 Hartslock Drive, Thamesmead SE2 9UR**, with the writer's name and address, stating if these details are to be omitted on printing. Neither the publisher, The Printing House Thamesmead Ltd, nor the editor, necessarily agrees with sentiments expressed in letters printed here but they endeavour to reproduce, within the law and with minimal editorial amendment, all the opinions of the community.

LETTERS DEADLINE – JULY 9

Sympathy

Dear Sir, it was with sympathy I read James Long's letter in the May edition.

Only the week previously, whilst walking my dog down the Green Chain Walk to Southmere, on a beautiful sunny Bank Holiday afternoon, I was continually taunted by a group of boys, aged between 11 and 12. They shouted "F****ing Old Granny". Cowards that they are, they then ran away. Several times they appeared with their same nonsense, always keeping well out of reach.

I was sorely tempted to let my dog free. Without a doubt he would have left his mark on at least one. I was deterred by the thought that he might chase them onto Yarnton Way which would have put not only my pet, but motorists, at risk.

On previous occasions I have witnessed these boys at their "play" taunting others. Despite being a Grannie (not the other word) I did not feel threatened, but rather pitied them for imagining that their cowardice was likely to arouse admiration from anyone.

The following day, when the "brave" boys were presumably safe at home preparing for school, I walked in Lesnes Park. Early in the morning, the trees were in bloom, the rhododendrons a mass of reds and golds, the sky brilliant blue, lawns and flower beds a picture to behold (thank you, ground staff) and, to cap it all, a carpet of bluebells as a background to the woods. The very air was fragrant.

Meeting an elderly gent with his terriers I was delighted by his greeting: "It's great to be alive, isn't it?" What a contrast!

Why should these pathetic kids get away with spoiling other people's lives? Like Mr Long, I am tempted to carry a camera – not to capture the beauty around me, but to obtain "mug" shots.

It would give me satisfaction to post these to schools and public places where proud parents could see and recognise their "products". Being a parent myself, I understand that they are probably unaware of how their youngsters get their "kicks".

Hopefully, they would then be able to deliver a few kicks of their own where it hurts. By the way, if anyone asks, yes, I always poop scoop.

Joan Faulds

Demonic destruction

Dear Sir, does anyone know who is responsible now for the maintenance and upkeep of the Thamesmead river frontage? So much of it is in a most distressed condition, completely out of keeping with the fresh image that is said to have been created and as portrayed in the promotional literature that regularly falls through the letterbox.

The vandalism to which the frontage is being subjected can only be described as demonic destruction. Beautifully constructed walls have been smashed literally to pieces and the remains left hazardously on the adjacent steps or hurled into the Thames – and the high level wall has been similarly blitzed. The new metal barriers (costing hundreds of pounds) on the Thames-side walk, and particularly the West frontage, have been ripped to scrap – by what force it's hard to imagine.

Apart from the generally run-down appearance of the river frontage on both the high level and low level paths, with graffiti and broken glass almost everywhere, the saddest spot must be the abused observation platform (with its magnificent river panorama) now generally trashed and deep in garbage, to an extent that the mental state of those responsible must be regarded as either mad or bad.

Surely something better can be made of our historic Thames frontage, which is perhaps Thamesmead's most unique asset?

Paul Kelliher

Now we know ...

Dear Sir, now we know. Since Gallions Housing Association (GHA) came into being following the demise of our previous "quango" landlord Thamesmead Town Ltd (TTL), the environmental state and appearance of the estate have deteriorated.

Also there has been an unacceptable level of vandalism and the everyday problem and eyesore of graffiti daubed all over the place. Not to say that GHA's anti-graffiti teams who are daily cleaning off the infantile, stupid, so-called "form-of-art", are not trying to counter the problem, with some measure of success, it seems, but seemingly are being followed around by the same stupid bunch of antisocial idiots who persist in defacing all and everywhere on the estate.

It also seems since GHA took over, no surprise to many residents, that estate security, or rather the lack of it, is one of the main problems – for which we now witness the consequences every day. The blatant dumping of rubbish all over the place, frequent incidents of bags of rubbish, even unwanted pieces of furniture, being thrown over balconies in Maran Way onto the road immediately below.

Then there is the ongoing problem, totally unchecked by GHA when it is regularly reported to them, of the three older persons' Courts (Shire, Teeswater and Buckwheat) being used as dumping grounds with all kinds of rubbish being dumped every day. In the main, by occupants of houses in Redpoll, Mangold and Holstein Ways. Where else is it coming from when the three older persons' Courts have their own refuse disposal hoppers/chutes *inside* the blocks?

And most of the dumped rubbish *is* in black plastic bags, many containing garden material – grass cuttings, weeds *etc* and, of course unwanted furniture.

Security? What security? Certain areas around these Courts are daily plagued by groups of downright anti-social, out-of-control children who find it amusing to throw eggs, stones and other items up at elderly person's windows. And one of the Courts and a nearby "kick-about" cage have been targets of dangerous air rifles firing lead pellets. If one of them, which can penetrate thick glazing, hits somebody, it could cause serious injury. Incidentally, GHA was alerted about this dangerous activity months ago – and it has recently started again. I suggest that GHA gets the Police involved in dealing with this highly dangerous and antisocial activity.

Continued on next page

U8s fantastic first season

DAVID SEALEY

THAMESMEAD Town FC U8s enjoyed a very successful first season. It began in September with 14 boys registered for TTFC. The first season was made up of non-league games but all of them were very competitive.

Next season we will be running two teams, the Thamesmead Tigers and the Thamesmead Lions. This has been necessary due to popular demand and the interest of boys wishing to play for the team. I thank Alan and Debbie Shepherd, Brierly Autos ands Wilcon Homes for their generous sponsorship this season – may it continue next season!

HIGHLIGHT

The season's highlight was reaching the cup final, but unfortunately later being told by the League that due to a decision made by the Bexley League we would not be going through!

On Saturday, May 19 we held a Presentation Disco at the Clubhouse of TTFC, with over 150 people attending. It was a gerat success, enjoyed by everyone. Trophies were awarded to the following boys:

Player of the year: Joe Benson-Reed;

Players' Player: Sam Risby;

Top Goal Scorer: Sam Risby (20 goals!);

Most Improved Player: Shay Gallant.

SILVER

The next day, after a heavy night, the team won their first silverware, the Grasshoppers' Challenge Shield, beating Eastcote Stars (1–0) and Grasshoppers (1–0). TTFC U8s played 46; won 24; drew 15; lost 7; goals for 70, against 33.

I was thrilled with the first season and I hope for a successful next season when the team will be playing in the Bexley League.



The lads, with Dave Sealey (pic supplied)

THE LEN COLE COLUMN

My old pal Charles A Brown retired on the last day of May. I first met Charlie when he came to work with me in the City in 1951 when he was just 15 years and I was 17.

Prior to this In had made a living at Catford dog track. The first time I went dog racing, aged 14, I did a 5p forecast on traps two and four. This obliged, and I won £2.50 (OK, £2 10s then), which was more than my friends earned in a week.

I heard some old timers saying that if a bitch was in season the dogs would follow behind her giving an easy win. Back in those days (1948) Catford was open on Thursdays and Saturdays.

The next time I went I found that a little black bitch named A Stout was running.

I had a ten shilling (50p) bet which earned me another £2 10s. I was delighted and went to the bar with some poor old dear named Doris.

She must have been getting on for forty and was having no luck at all. I bought us both a glass of stout, which I thought was sort of poetic.

With the approach of National Service I had to get a job. There was no unemployment back then and the only people without insurance cards were criminals, and when you registered for the army you had to state your occupation.

I didn't think they would believe me if I put my employment down as "punter". That's how I came to meet Charlie.

Fifty years on we have arranged to have a swift half or two to celebrate our half-century frendship.

I thought that I should never support those who suggest that the death penalty be reintroduced.

However, since I heard that murder by gunmen has increased this year, despite it being illegal to own a gun, I ahve changed my mind. These gunmen obviously agree with the death penalty because they sentence people to death and execute them. The fact that they possess a firearm makes their actions premeditated. Therefore they should have no objection to being put to death themsleves. Hanging is a bit barbaric, so perhaps a firing squad would be more appropriate.

Let the punishment fir the crime. This would save the cost of keeping someone in prison, making more money available to improve the Police force and cut down the rate of repeat offenders.

Now for the serious bit. I overheard two intellectual types discussing old English literature. One of them believed that originally a Humpty Dumpty was one who had been humped and dumped! You elarn something new every day, don't you?

Well look after yourselves and good luck, Len.

Community RESPOND Matters

Respond Community Matters

19 Purland Road
West Thamesmead
Business Park
Thamesmead SE28 0AT
Telephone 020 8310 8808
Fax 020 8311 8188

Respond Community Matters is an umbrella community project designed to support the local community and provide help and support for community organisations

We are able to offer help with:
• Setting up new projects • Constitutions • Management structures • Getting charitable status • Fundraising • Minutes • Agendas • Posters • Logos • Flyers and Brochures • Web Sites • Press Releases and much, much more ...

Contact our office at the number shown or speak to us directly:

Gary Redding – 07949 588927
Mary Chambers – 07939 048955

Respond is a registered charity number 1070472

It is now high time that GHA faces up to all the serious antisocial problems mentioned above and does something positive about them – and reinstates estate security patrols in the *residential areas* instead of throwing our money, rent and service-charges, at fancy projects like the Limestone area for instance, which should have been way down the so-called "priorities list". *Denis Thompson-Mason*

Carry on

Dear Sir, Denis Turner scores doubly with his letter in the May *People*. He has hit the proverbial nail on the head and also caps the concomitant issues variously raised to date. Not just his own, but in those of the previously published letters respectively from Messrs Shu Nguyen, Denis Thompson-Mason, Paul Kelliher and Ray Hutchins.

The Housing Corporation London too, as the statutory regulator of housing associations and suchlike, must inevitably realise the present set-up over here is nothing more than a pantomime farce in the theatre of the absurd. The Gallions Housing Association and assorted bandwagons in various guises is simply a carry-on of Thamesmead Town horrors by other means. Down to the very same people being in charge now as then. With confirmation of the whole scheming business displayed in all its colour and gloss across the reams of printed propaganda put out during the course of 1999 under the banner heading of "A better deal – with news about the proposals to improve Thamesmead Town".

Faced with a situation best described by that apt French proverb about the more changes there are then things remain just the same, the Corporation falls back on the futile step of trying to "ring in the changes" through the first of its Annual Performance Appraisals, due to be conducted early this Summer. The results of which are to subsequently form the basis of a framework for real change into the future.

Before everyone rushes off with excitement to put their faith in the Housing Corporation to act as their safeguard of lawful entitlements, it is vital to heed a couple of forewarnings. By its own proud boasts it is the "biggest quango" (= quasi autonomous national government organisation) in the land. While its performance as statutory regulator has recently come under fire from the House of Commons Public Accounts Committee over the case of serious fraud at Focus Housing Association in the Midlands, which resulted in three criminal convictions being handed down (*Financial Times*, May 2).

Turning about four pages before the one where Denis Turner's letter is to be found, the latest stage of this interminable Punch & Judy show appears. There, unfolded across the centre spread, it proclaims "The first exercise: we can make it work, together" in bold red letters. Interspersed with platitudes as usual. Plus a familiar perennial contender making quite a telling pitch: "As a sitting board member I already have training and knowledge of how to deal with and decide day-to-day issues. Vote for me and have a ready-trained board member" and assures us even further that he has " … for 18 years … represented residents in many forums and at all levels … ".

"This time, this part of the democratic process is being enacted first … " which plainly means that was not so last time. And the same people were in charge then as now. So why should they be trusted " … to keep the democratisation process going forward … "?

Answers to such questions and more besides are long overdue and being disparaged with patronising knocker/whinger labels – by typically vested interests – whenever efforts are made to obtain these, it is a tendency of habitual carpers being coy about the hidden agenda at play. More so when their own words inadvertently betray their actual stances.

With good reason does that chap alongside of the Gallions' logo smile in anticipation while chalking his cue – you are being snookered. *Vaughan Porritt*

Unfortunate

Dear Sir, it is unfortunate that the *Thamesmead People* seems to have lost its objectivity where Gallions Housing Association (GHA) and the EMBs is concerned.

Your May edition urges us to vote for these venerable institutions in the forthcoming June elections. But I am still not sure exactly what I am supposed to be voting for!

If it were a town council or borough council it would be more clear cut. But what we seem to have is a board (sounds familiar – just like TTL?) with lots of little boards. Three tiers of democracy all costing the residents' rent and charge money from our pockets, which could be better spent on improvements and better services in Thamesmead.

Recently, my elderly neighbour was burgled and evidence of possible drug-taking was found on the stairwells. Naturally and dutifully I contacted our beloved Gallions and asked them if they could look into the matter and issue a written letter to all local residents to be vigilant about who they allow into the block, particularly when answering the door intercom (there is no cctv here).

The answer was "No," they couldn't look into the drug evidence, that was a matter for the Police; "Yes," they would distribute a letter but there would be a delay because of *staff shortage*.

Hang on! *Staff shortage?* Does that not tell us something about the brave new world of Gallions? If GHA is so shiny and new, how come its own workers are deserting it in droves; how come they can't write a simple letter and distribute it to 48 homes within a couple of days? This is not exactly brain surgery, after all.

Talking of brain surgery haven't doctors and nurses been deserting the NHS? Police leaving the Police Service and teachers jumping the education service? Seems like Gallions is going to be next in line for a service breakdown. Vote in June if you dare for Gallions, but think very carefully first. *Denis Turner*

Abbey Wood & Thamesmead GINGERBREAD

AW&T Gingerbread will commence at Linton Mead School, off Central Way, Thamesmead, SE28 (please use third gate), 12-2 on Fridays, June 15, July 6 and July 20. During school holidays meetings will be at the Jubilee Hall, Lytton Strachey Path, Thamesmead SE28 on August 10 and 24, then back to Linton Mead for September 14 and 28.

For further details contact Jacqueline Smith on 020 8310 7623 or Danny Breach on 020 8312 4032.

Meet the Bexley Police

Belvedere Sector Working Party meetings: 7.30pm in Erith Town Hall on

Monday, August 13

and

Monday, November 19

Next year's dates not yet decided

Fishing for Kids

Thamesmead Town Angling Club

Membership now only £10 per season for those aged 10–16 years. Free tuition by senior Club members.

Get your applications in now – contact bailiffs on the bank, Ron Summers Tackle or any existing senior member

rod licences have also been reduced to £5 for juniors.

Membership entitles you to fish all waters in Thamesmead

TABLE SALE

From June 2 there will be a table sale every first Saturday of the month at the Limestone Community Hall, Limestone Walk, Thamesmead

To get to the Hall by bus, routes 401, 180 and B11 all stop at the Limestone Walk bus stop. Those who would like a table there, please get in touch with Wendy on 0794 6563157, or call in to see her on Thursday afternoons in the Hall at the Senior Citizens' Bingo Club there, between 2 and 4pm.

She can also be found in the Hall on Thursday evenings at E&G Bingo, from 6 to 8pm. Cost of tables £6

Monday Club Bingo

2-4pm

all welcome

contact Dot Martin at the Jubilee Hall, Titmus Avenue, Thamesmead

020 8311 5707

Kick Boxing and Self Defence Club

At the Jubilee Hall, Titmus Avenue, Thamesmead

Monday 7-8.30, seniors

Tuesday, 6-7 juniors

Tuesday, 7-8 seniors

Thursday, 5-6, mixed class (basics)

Phone Glenn on

07866 174838

(new number)



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RESOURCES

ABBEY WOOD and THAMESMEAD VOLUNTEERING PROJECT

Volunteers can find the Project, 1–4pm, Mondays, at GHA Resource Centre, Harrow Manor Way; 10–1pm Wednesdays at Thamesmead YAP, Tavy Bridge; 11–2pm, Thursdays at C2K, Eynsham Drive, Abbey Wood.

LEGAL ADVICE

THAMESMEAD LAW CENTRE. Free, independent Legal Advice for residents. Appointments, call at St Paul's Church, Bentham Road, Thamesmead, 10am–1pm any weekday or call 020 8311 0555.

ADVICE/SUPPORT GROUPS

BEXLEY GAY GROUP

Meets weekly in Crayford, provides confidential support and social venue to members of local gay community. Contact The Metro Centre on 020 8265 3311.

CHINESE INFORMATION CENTRE 020 7692 3471.

DOMESTIC VIOLENCE HELPLINE

Domestic Violence 24-hr Helpline 0870 599 5443 - IMMEDIATE ADVICE.

FAMILY SERVICE UNIT 1/3 Maran Way, Thamesmead. Family advice and support. **020 8310 6570.**

FOUR-LEGGED FRIENDS Rescue Centre, Southmere Park, off Hartslock Drive. Contact 020 8311 5086.

GREENWICH WOMEN'S CENTRE 020 8317 4141.

IRISH IN GREENWICH Free legal advice surgeries first and second Tuesdays of month. 020 8854 4466.

REFUGE for Women with Learning Difficulties 020 8522 0675.

WOMEN'S AID National Helpline 0845 7023 468.

SAMARITANS 0845 790 9090.

CLAUDE RAMSEY LIBRARY

Thamesmere Pools, Thamesmead Drive SE28 8RE
Telephone 020 8310 4246
Mon: 2.00-7.00; Tues: closed; Wed 10.00-12.30, 1.30-5.30; Thurs 2.00-7.00; Fri 10.00-12.30, 1.30-5.30; Sat 10.00-12.30, 1.30-5.00

Greenwich Libraries

GREENWICH

THAMESMEAD LIBRARY

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Telephone 020 8310 9944
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Tues: 9.30-5.30 Fri: 9.30-8.00
Wed: 9.30-1.00 Sat: 9.30-5.00

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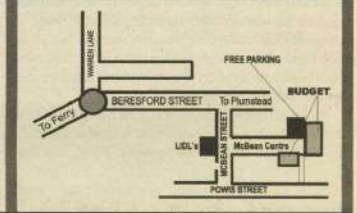
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THAMESMEAD CONSCIENCE

This is a monthly column written by an individual not connected to the *People* or any other business. It is intended to provoke thought ...

Later this year the Government will be establishing targets for protecting the environment, recycling and the reduction of waste going to landfill. This means that local councils will receive targets for recycling and will have to invest in awareness and education information about recycling and environmental waste issues.

This will be of particular interest to the people of Thamesmead who will be living under the shadow of the new Belvedere incinerator. Not purely there to dispose of local waste, but also to collect waste from all over London to bring into and through our town and neighbouring boroughs. If you have read the information document on the incinerator you will have read how lucky you are to have such a facility near your home. I wonder if this would be the same opinion if the incinerator were placed in Hammersmith or Wandsworth?

Bexley Council has shown great delight, and rightly so, in achieving Beacon status for waste initiatives and recycling in the Borough. Greenwich is one of the worst achievers in this area. It is therefore difficult to understand why neither of these Councils provide recycling credits, which is financial support to the businesses and charities working in the boroughs who are already engaged in large-scale recycling and environmental concerns that improve all of our lives.

Thousands of tonnes of waste are prevented from going to landfill each year by these groups and most of them recycle goods and products for the benefit of the area in which they work. Examples of this would be computers being provided for students to help with their studies, furniture being recycled and renovated to provide basic housing and living standards for people below the poverty line, or for re-housing of homeless people.

I suggest that the only reason Bexley would support an incinerator is for the money they will make from having other people dumping their rubbish in and around our town. The reason the councils do not support local groups is that they do not financially benefit from it. I believe the same rule applies to the selling of land across both boroughs, but particularly the areas in Greenwich around Thamesmead town centre. There is very little green land left in Thamesmead and a robust policy of selling all land available by Tilfen Limited has been employed to maximise profit.

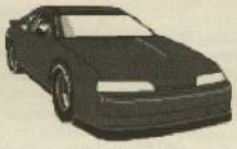
Tilfen is, of course, part of the old Thamesmead Town Limited whose only shareholders are Gallions Housing and Trust Thamesmead. They are financially benefiting from the sale of the land because the more the shares are worth the more money these groups receive. The ultimate goal for these groups is to ensure that a bridge is built over the Thames through the Thames Gateway carrying thousands more cars and lorries through our town and boroughs. This would increase the value of Tilfen Limited and the shareholders will be delighted. The original plan for Thamesmead was of course to be linked to London through a rail network with much less pollution, noise and health risk. If you suffer from asthma, bronchitis or just like country walks, I am sure you will not be welcoming the additional pollution from the incinerator, the increased air pollution from more vehicles and the sale of nearly all of the green land in the area.

If you do not believe that a bit more traffic can cause this huge increase in pollution consider this: the 2001 election resulted in leaders travelling to all different parts of the country. The nine election buses travelling around the country covered over 100,00 miles. They spent around £45,000 on fuel and created an estimated 84 tonnes of carbon dioxide. The comparison would be you motoring in a family saloon for the next 26 years.

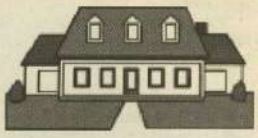
If you are not concerned about the river crossing but are concerned about the environment, remember the paper used in the election would have required the wood from 100,000 trees covering an area of 32 square miles or about the size of 100 football pitches.

Both the environment and recycling to reduce landfill are important to ordinary people, and will now be used by politicians to convince you that they are doing good. Look around at the number of people already working locally in these areas without adding pollution and traffic congestion to the town. Then ask yourself how you will benefit from a huge incinerator being on your doorstep or thousands more cars and lorries thundering past our houses, schools and businesses. If you're worried, remember you voted for John Austin MP to serve you. Let him know how you feel.

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